

Cārvāka / Lokāyata — Theory of Knowledge and Rejection of Transcendent Entities — Complete Learning Session

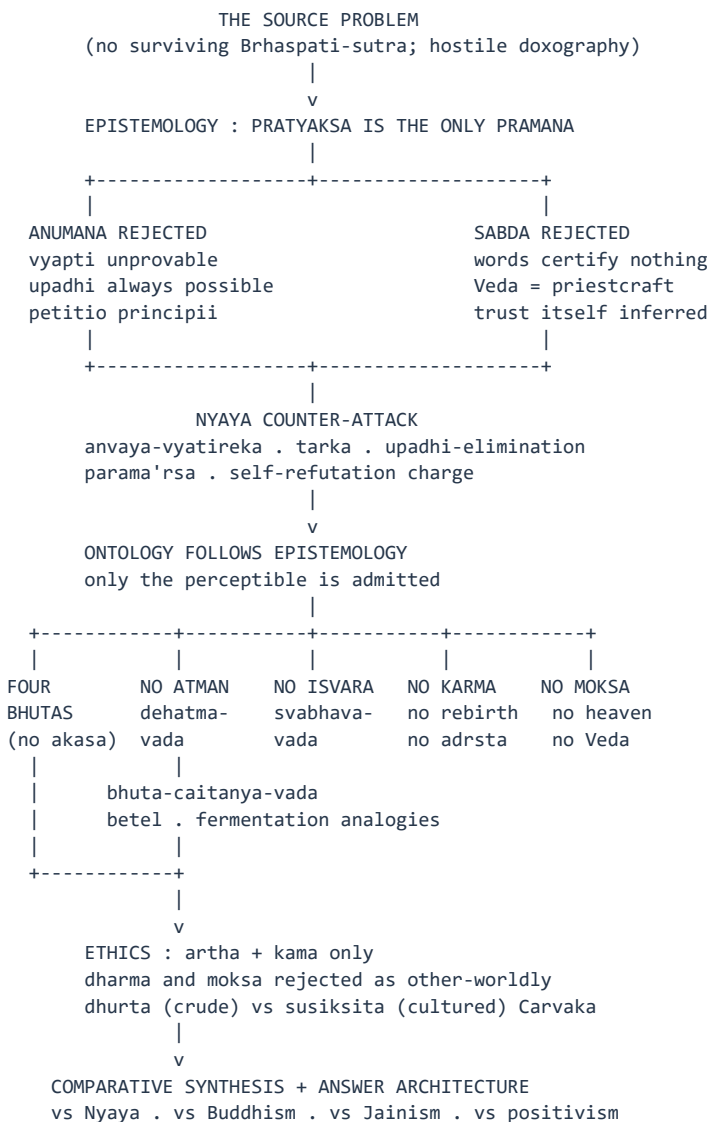
UPSC Philosophy Optional · Paper I · Section B · Indian Philosophy · Syllabus item 12

Date of session: 10 August 2026 · Progress: 0/9 · Estimated effort: 6–8 sittings

Evidence key used throughout: ✓ canonical doctrine directly grounded in the authored knowledge file or in a local OCR-searchable source text · △ analytical synthesis / inference for exam use · ? contested, textually uncertain or transmitted only through hostile doxography · ↻ clearly labelled contemporary conceptual parallel, never presented as a dated current-affairs item and never as authority.

Sources actually used for this session. ✓ Authored Markdown paper-1/indian/Carvaka.md (read in full); ✓ Satishchandra Chatterjee and Dhirendramohan Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*, Chapter II, "The Cārvāka Philosophy" — read from the two local OCR-searchable copies; ✓ C. D. Sharma, *Indian Philosophy: A Critical Survey*, Chapter Three, "Materialism"; ✓ paper-1/indian/Jainism.md for the 2020 Cārvāka–Jaina comparison; ✓ paper-1/_PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md for exact question wording. Qdrant was not required and did not block the session.

Roadmap



Session	Subtopic	Core focus
1	Historical reconstruction and the source problem	Lokāyata, Cārvāka, Bārhaspatya; the lost Bṛhaspati-sūtra; hostile transmission; Jayarāśi; why the school is nāstika
2	Epistemology — perception as the sole pramāṇa	Pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda; external and internal perception; certainty versus practical belief; why śabda and upamāna fall
3	The critique of inference	Vyāpti, the class-character reply, upādhi, petitio principii, the Socrates syllogism, self-refutation and the Cārvāka's best replies
4	The Nyāya defence of inference	Anvaya-vyatireka, tarka, upādhi-elimination, parāmarśa, vyāptigraha; a critically balanced verdict
5	Metaphysics and materialism	Four bhūtas, the rejection of ākāśa, bhūta-caitanya-vāda, betel and fermentation analogies, svabhāvavāda, yadr̥cchāvāda
6	Self, body and consciousness	Dehātmanvāda, caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā, first-person statements, memory and personal identity; Cārvāka versus Buddhist anātman (2024, 20 marks)
7	Rejection of transcendent entities	God, soul, karma, rebirth, transmigration, adṛṣṭa, heaven and hell, mokṣa, Vedic authority and priestcraft
8	Ethics and the political-social meaning	Artha and kāma; refined versus crude hedonism; the "debt and ghee" verse and its source caution; naturalism, secularism, positivism; Cārvāka versus Jaina reality (2020)
9	Comparative synthesis and answer architecture	The master matrix, graded verdicts, 10/15/20-mark architecture, complete PYQ routing, original practice

PYQ priority: ✓ Very high for a small syllabus item — 9 primary-owned question-parts out of 112 across 2018–2025, spanning the rejection of inference (2018, 2019 twice, 2025), ākāśa and transmigration (2020), Cārvāka versus Jaina reality (2020), epistemology and transcendent entities (2021), positivism (2024) and the Cārvāka–Buddhist self comparison (2024). Only 2022 and 2023 carry no primary-owned Cārvāka part — and even 2022 carries a cross-linked Nyāya part built entirely on Cārvāka's objections.

🔗 Master mnemonic — "ONE, FOUR, TWO, ZERO": ONE pramāṇa (perception) · FOUR elements (no ākāśa) · TWO puruṣārthas (artha, kāma) · ZERO transcendent entities (no soul, God, karma, rebirth, mokṣa, Vedic authority).

⚠ The single sentence that organises the whole topic: Cārvāka's ontology is not an independent metaphysical whim; it is the exact ontological shadow cast by an epistemology that admits only perception. Every answer in this syllabus item should be able to run backwards from any denial to that one epistemic premise.

Progress: 1 / 9 | Stage: Foundation | Subtopic: Historical Reconstruction and the Source Problem

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

📖 Book context: Authored Markdown paper-1/indian/Carvaka.md §2.8 and §4.4 read in full; local OCR-searchable Chatterjee and Datta, An Introduction to Indian Philosophy, Chapter II §I ("Its Origin and Scope") and §V ("Conclusion") consulted directly; C. D. Sharma, Indian Philosophy: A Critical Survey, Chapter Three §I–II ("Introduction" and "Sources") consulted directly.

🔍 CA Search: "Cārvāka / Lokāyata — new manuscript, textual discovery or scholarly development, February–August 2026"

📖 CA Found: None in last 6 months. No credible, major Cārvāka-specific development is datable inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. This subtopic is therefore taught from canonical doctrine and textual history, which is exactly what the syllabus item requires. 🔗 A conceptual parallel — the historiographical problem of reconstructing a position known only through its opponents — is flagged at the end of the subtopic and is clearly labelled as a conceptual link, not a news item.



VISUAL — How we know what we know about Cārvāka

WHAT WOULD BE IDEAL
=====

BRHASPATI-SUTRA (primary)
|
| direct transmission
v
Carvaka commentaries
|
v
Living school with pupils

WHAT WE ACTUALLY HAVE
=====

(LOST)
|
| about a dozen sutras and
| verses quoted by OTHERS
v
+-----+
| HOSTILE DOXOGRAPHY |
| Sarva-darsana-sangraha |
| Sad-darsana-samuccaya |
| Prabodhacandrodaya (play)|
| Tattvasangraha (Buddhist)|
| Vedantasara (Advaita) |
+-----+
|
| refutation-first framing:
| strongest points omitted,
| weakest points magnified
|
v
+ ONE surviving sceptical text
TATTVOPAPLAVASIMHA
(Jayarasi Bhatta, c. 8th c. CE)
-- but it is MORE sceptical
than the standard Carvaka

⚠️ Caption. Every claim in this topic passes through a filter of refutation. That does not make reconstruction impossible; it makes epistemic honesty about the reconstruction itself a mark-earning move. The examiner rewards a candidate who writes "on the standard doxographical reconstruction" rather than one who quotes a lost text as though it were open on the desk.

1. The three names, and what each one tells you

Name	Literal sense	What it signals	Evidence status
Cārvāka	Possibly from carv, "to chew, to eat" — the doctrine of "eat, drink and be merry"; or from cāru-vāk, "sweet-worded / pleasant of speech"	Either a hostile nickname or a note that the doctrine is superficially attractive	✓ Both etymologies are given in Chatterjee and Datta; C. D. Sharma adds a third gloss — one who "chews up" merit and demerit
Lokāyata	Lokāyata-mata, "the view of the common people"; a lokāyatika is its holder	The school is popular, worldly, this-worldly; by implication in hostile sources, unrefined	✓ Chatterjee and Datta; Sharma adds that "commoner" carries a pejorative implication of low taste in the sources
Bārhaspatya	"Of Bṛhaspati"	Traces the school to Bṛhaspati as its traditional founder	✓ Sharma: "Bṛhaspati, a heretical teacher, is regarded as the traditional founder of this school. His Sūtra ... has unfortunately perished."

✓ There is a further doxographical curiosity, reported in both Chatterjee and Datta and Sharma: some accounts identify this Bṛhaspati with the teacher of the gods, who is said to have propagated materialism among the asuras precisely so

that, following these attractive teachings, they would come to ruin. ? That story is polemical theology, not history; quote it only to illustrate how the tradition was framed by its enemies.

⚠ Exam use. Opening a 10-marker with "Cārvāka, also called Lokāyata and Bārhaspatya, is the materialist and nāstika school of Indian philosophy" costs one line and immediately signals command of the nomenclature.

2. The source problem, stated precisely

✓ The facts, as the standard textbooks state them.

1. No systematic primary work of the school survives. Chatterjee and Datta: "we do not find any systematic work on materialism, nor any organised school of followers as the other philosophical schools possess."
2. The Bṛhaspati-sūtra is lost. Sharma: about a dozen sūtras and verses are found quoted or referred to by other authors as the materialistic teachings of Bṛhaspati.
3. "Almost every work of the other schools states, for refutation, the materialistic views. Our knowledge of Indian materialism is chiefly based on these" (Chatterjee and Datta).
4. Sharma is blunter about the consequence: "the weak points in this school are exaggerated and the strong points are omitted. So we get only a faint caricature and not a true picture."
5. Sharma adds the decisive historiographical warning: even the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha summary "seems to be based on such accounts", so it does not give independent access to the school.

⚠ What follows philosophically. Three consequences, each usable as a line in an answer:

- (a) MODAL CAUTION : write "on the standard reconstruction", not "Carvaka says in his text".
- (b) CHARITY : where a doctrine has a crude and a defensible version, the crude one is the one an enemy would preserve. Reconstruct the strongest available reading and SAY that you are doing so.
- (c) NON-PARALYSIS : convergence across independent hostile sources on the same doctrinal core (perceptualism, anti-inferentialism, four elements, no soul, no afterlife) is itself evidence.

3. The surviving fragments — what is actually quoted

✓ Sharma gleans the following from the Bṛhaspati material quoted across philosophical writings. These are the closest thing to primary text that exists, and they are quoted by others:

#	Sūtra (as transmitted)	Doctrine
1	prthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni	Earth, water, fire and air are the elements
2	tatsamudāye śarīrendriyaviśaya-saṃjñā	Bodies, senses and objects are results of different combinations of the elements
3	kiṇvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam	Consciousness arises from matter as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents
4	caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ	The person is the body qualified by consciousness
5	kāma evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ	Enjoyment is the only end of human life
6	marāṇam eva apavargaḥ	Death alone is liberation

✓ Alongside these, the second act of Kṛṣṇamiśra's allegorical play Prabodhacandrodaya summarises the doctrine in a single sweep: "Lokāyata is the only śāstra; perception is the only authority; earth, water, fire and air are the only elements; enjoyment is the only end of human existence; mind is only a product of matter. There is no other world; death means liberation."

? Caution to carry through the whole session. A play written by an opponent, staged as allegory, is a representation of the doctrine. It is legitimate evidence of how the school was understood; it is not the school's own voice.

4. Why Cārvāka is nāstika — and the exact sense of the word

✓ This is a precision point that separates strong scripts from weak ones. Chatterjee and Datta set it out exactly:

Sense of āstika	Meaning in Sanskrit philosophical literature	Is Cārvāka nāstika in this sense?
Primary, classificatory sense	One who accepts the authority of the Vedas	✓ Yes — this is the sense that generates the six-āstika / three-nāstika division
Secondary sense	One who believes in life after death	✓ Yes
Modern vernacular sense	"Theist" versus "atheist"	⚠ Misleading. Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā and early Yoga-adjacent readings are non-theistic yet āstika

✓ Chatterjee and Datta state the consequence directly: the six orthodox schools are āstika, "and the Cārvāka is nāstika in both the senses". Jaina and Bauddha schools are nāstika on the first criterion but would count as āstika on the second, since they accept life after death.

🔗 *Trap, and it is examined: Cārvāka is nāstika primarily because it rejects Vedic authority, not merely because it denies God. If denial of God were the criterion, Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā would also be nāstika — and they are not.*

5. Why materialism arose — the historical setting

✓ Sharma gives the standard account: the school "seems to be very old", with references in the epics and in early Buddhist literature; Garbe is quoted to the effect that "even in the pre-Buddhistic India proclaimers of purely materialistic doctrines appeared." Sharma locates its rise in the post-Upaniṣadic and pre-Buddhistic age and attributes it to:

1. protest against the excessive monkdom of the Brāhmaṇa priests;
2. the externals of ritualism, "which ignored the substance and emphasized the shadow";
3. an Upaniṣadic idealism "unsuited to the commoners";
4. political and social crises, exploitation of the masses by petty rulers, monks and the wealthy class.

✓ Early Buddhist scripture confirms an environment of such thinkers. The Sāmaññaphala-sutta names four contemporaries of the Buddha whom Chatterjee and Datta group as "cunning (dhūrta) Cārvākas":

Thinker	Position as reported
Pūraṇa Kassapa	Denies moral responsibility, virtue and vice
Makkhali Gosāla	Denies free will and the possibility of moral effort
Ajita Kesakambalī	Teaches the material origin and destructibility of man, the futility of good action, the impossibility of knowledge
Sañjaya Belaṭṭhiputta	Will neither affirm, nor deny, nor both, nor even admit that he neither affirms nor denies

✓ Sharma independently notes Ajita Kesakambalin in the Majjhima Nikāya as "a materialist ... who believed only in perception and in four elements", and records that Śāntarākṣita refers to him as Kambalāśvatara.

⚠ Exam use. Naming Ajita Kesakambalī gives you a pre-systematic historical anchor for four-element materialism that is independent of the hostile Brahmanical doxography — a genuinely strong evidential move in a 15- or 20-marker on sources.

6. Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa — the one surviving text, and why it must be handled carefully

✓ The facts. Chatterjee and Datta: the Tattvopaplavasīmha, by Jayarāśi, "probably of the eighth century A.D.", is a "recently discovered manuscript" and "an interesting specimen of Indian absolute scepticism"; its author "is believed to be a Cārvāka (or Lokāyatika) of an extreme type." Sharma records the publication data: it is the "single exception" to the absence of extant works, published by the Oriental Institute of Baroda in 1940.

✓ What Jayarāśi actually does. He "carries the scepticism of the ordinary Cārvāka to its logical conclusion by challenging the validity of perceptual knowledge and refusing to accept the existence of even the physical elements. With a relentless destructive dialectic he exposes the defects of all the usually accepted sources of knowledge." His conclusion, Chatterjee and Datta note, is that of "an anti-intellectualist pragmatist": even on the denial of all theoretical principles and doctrines, practical life will go on as ever with unreflective ease.

△ The distinction that must be preserved.

STANDARD CARVAKA

 Perception is VALID
 Four elements are REAL
 Positive materialist ontology
 Rejects inference and testimony
 = dogmatic empiricism

JAYARASI'S SCEPTICISM

 Perception is ALSO attacked
 Even the elements are not admitted
 NO positive ontology at all
 Rejects EVERY pramana
 = universal scepticism (tattva-upaplava,
 "the upsetting of all principles")

△ Why this matters for the exam. It is tempting, and wrong, to use Jayarāśi as evidence for what "the Cārvākas" held about perception. If Jayarāśi is used to establish the school's epistemology, the school's defining thesis — that perception alone is a pramāṇa — disappears. Use him for exactly two things: (i) as the sole surviving text-witness of the tradition, and (ii) as the internal limit-case showing where consistent Cārvāka scepticism, pressed hard, ends up.

7. Solved PYQ material — the source problem inside an answer

△ No PYQ asks directly about sources; every PYQ is improved by one sentence about them. Use one of these calibrated formulations:

Marks	Sentence to insert	Where
10	"Since the Bṛhaspati-sūtra is lost, the position is reconstructed from doxographies such as the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha."	After the opening definition
15	"Because the sources are refutational, the crude version of any Cārvāka doctrine is the one most likely to have been preserved; the argument below therefore reconstructs the strongest defensible reading."	Before the critical evaluation
20	"The historiographical caution cuts both ways: it forbids confident quotation, but the convergence of Buddhist (Tattvasaṅgraha), Advaita (Vedāntasāra), Jaina (Ṣaḍ-darśana-samuccaya) and Advaita-adjacent doxographical accounts on the same doctrinal core is itself independent evidence for that core."	In the evaluation paragraph

Advanced refinement

△ Cārvāka was not marginal to Indian philosophy; it was structural. Chatterjee and Datta make the point in their concluding section and it is worth reproducing as an evaluative sentence: "every system of Indian thought tried to meet the Cārvāka objections and made the Cārvāka a touchstone of its theories." They add that its value "lies directly in supplying fresh philosophical problems and indirectly in compelling other thinkers to give up dogmatism, and become critical and cautious in speculation as well as in the statement of views" — and they compare this to Kant's admission that "the scepticism of Hume roused me from my dogmatic slumber."

△ Sharma's counterweight, which a balanced answer should also carry: "Materialism in Indian Philosophy has never been a force. Born in discontent, it soon died in serious thought." The two verdicts are not contradictory: Cārvāka failed as a positive system while succeeding as a critical function. That two-sided judgement is exactly the graded verdict UPSC rewards.

Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

 The reconstruction problem here belongs to a general class: how to state fairly a position preserved only in the words of those who rejected it. The same methodological question arises in reading the Greek Sophists through Plato, or the Presocratics through Aristotle. △ Use this as a methodological remark of one sentence. It is a conceptual parallel, not a dated development, and it must never be written as though it were news.

UPSC traps

1. ? Do not write that "Cārvāka wrote the Bṛhaspati-sūtra". The text is lost; about a dozen sūtras survive only as quotations in other authors' works.
2. △ Do not treat the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha as an independent primary source. Sharma explicitly says its summary "seems to be based on" the same refutational accounts.
3. △ Do not use Jayarāṣi's Tattvopaplavasīṃha to state the Cārvāka theory of knowledge. He attacks perception too, which no standard Cārvāka does.
4. ✓ Do not say Cārvāka is nāstika "because it is atheist". It is nāstika because it rejects the authority of the Veda — and, in the second textbook sense, because it denies life after death.
5. △ Do not present the "asura-deception" story about Bṛhaspati as history.
6. △ Do not conclude from the source problem that "nothing can be known". Convergent hostile testimony still fixes a doctrinal core.
7. △ Do not confuse Lokāyata ("view of the common people") with "folk religion". It names a philosophical position, not a devotional practice.

Revision notes

- ✓ Three names: Cārvāka (carv, to chew / cāru-vāk, sweet-worded), Lokāyata (lokāyata-mata, the view of common people), Bārhaspatya (of Bṛhaspati).
- ✓ Bṛhaspati is the traditional founder; his Sūtra is lost; about a dozen sūtras survive as quotations.
- ✓ Knowledge of the school comes chiefly from works that state its views in order to refute them.
- ✓ Sharma's verdict on transmission: strong points omitted, weak points exaggerated — "a faint caricature and not a true picture".
- ✓ Six transmitted sūtras to memorise: four elements · bodies-senses-objects from combination · consciousness like intoxicating power · person = body qualified by consciousness · kāma the only end · death alone is liberation.
- ✓ Prabodhacandrodaya Act II gives the classic one-sentence summary of the school.
- ✓ Nāstika in both senses: rejects Vedic authority; denies life after death. Vedic authority is the primary classificatory criterion.
- ✓ Sāmaññaphala-sutta names Pūraṇa Kassapa, Makkhali Gosāla, Ajita Kesakambalī and Sañjaya Belaṭṭhiputta as the environment of early scepticism and materialism.
- ✓ Ajita Kesakambalī — "believed only in perception and in four elements" — is the best independent historical anchor for the doctrine.
- ✓ Jayarāṣi Bhaṭṭa, Tattvopaplavasīṃha, c. 8th century CE, published Baroda 1940 — the single surviving text, but an extreme sceptic who attacks perception itself.
- △ Cārvāka was the touchstone every school had to answer; its historical value is critical rather than constructive.
- △ Two-sided verdict to carry: philosophically fertile as critique (Chatterjee–Datta), unsuccessful as a system (Sharma).

MCQ 1

Which of the following most accurately states the primary classificatory reason Cārvāka is grouped among the nāstika schools of Indian philosophy?

- A. It rejects the authority of the Vedas, which is the standard Sanskrit philosophical criterion of āstika; on the secondary criterion it is also nāstika because it denies life after death.
- B. It denies the existence of God, which is what nāstika means in Sanskrit philosophical literature.
- C. It denies the existence of the external world and therefore falls outside the orthodox fold.
- D. It was founded later than the six orthodox systems and so could not be admitted into the āstika list.

✓ Correct answer: A. Chatterjee and Datta state the two senses explicitly: āstika means one who believes in the authority of the Vedas, or one who believes in life after death, and "the Cārvāka is nāstika in both the senses." B is the modern vernacular sense, and it fails immediately, because Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā are non-theistic yet āstika. C inverts the doctrine — Cārvāka is a realist about the perceptible world. D confuses chronology with classification.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 2

A candidate writes: "The Tattvopaplavasiṃha of Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa is the surviving primary text of the Cārvāka school, and it therefore gives us direct access to the Cārvāka theory that perception alone is a valid means of knowledge." What is the decisive error?

A. Jayarāśi was a Naiyāyika, not a Cārvāka.

B. Jayarāśi's work is sceptical about perception itself and refuses to admit even the physical elements, so it cannot be used to establish the standard Cārvāka thesis that perception alone is a pramāṇa.

C. The Tattvopaplavasiṃha is not extant; only fragments are quoted by other authors.

D. Jayarāśi accepts inference and therefore contradicts nothing in Cārvāka epistemology.

✓ Correct answer: B. Chatterjee and Datta describe Jayarāśi as a Cārvāka "of an extreme type" who "carries the scepticism of the ordinary Cārvāka to its logical conclusion by challenging the validity of perceptual knowledge and refusing to accept the existence of even the physical elements." A is false — he is placed inside the tradition. C is false — Sharma records its publication by the Oriental Institute of Baroda in 1940, and it is precisely the "single exception" to the loss of the corpus. D reverses his position; he rejects all the accepted sources of knowledge.

✓ Subtopic 1 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now state the nomenclature, the source situation and the exact sense in which Cārvāka is nāstika, and you can distinguish the historical school from Jayarāśi's radical scepticism. Proceeding to the theory of knowledge.

Progress: 2 / 9 | Stage: Foundation | Subtopic: Epistemology — Perception as the Sole Pramāṇa

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

📖 Book context: Carvaka.md §1.1, §1.4 and §1.7 read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §II ("The Cārvāka Epistemology"), including sub-sections 1 ("Inference is not Certain") and 2 ("Testimony is not a Safe Source of Knowledge"), read directly from the local OCR-searchable copy; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §III ("Epistemology") read directly.

🔍 CA Search: "empiricism, perception and the limits of testimony — Cārvāka epistemology, developments February–August 2026"

📅 CA Found: None in last 6 months. There is no credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. 🔗 A clearly labelled conceptual link to contemporary debates about the epistemology of testimony and misinformation is given at the end of the subtopic; it is a conceptual parallel, not a current-affairs anchor, and carries no evidential weight in the answer.



VISUAL — The pramāṇa ledger of Indian philosophy, and where Cārvāka stands

	pratyaksa (percep.)	anumana (infer.)	upamana (compar.)	sabda (test.)	arthapatti (postul.)	anupalabdh (non-cogn.)	
CARVAKA	YES	no	no	no	no	no	= 1
Vaisesika	YES	YES	no	no	no	no	= 2
Buddhism	YES	YES	no	no	no	no	= 2
Samkhya / Yoga	YES	YES	no	YES	no	no	= 3
Nyaya	YES	YES	YES	YES	no	no	= 4
Prabhakara Mimamsa	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	no	= 5
Bhatta Mimamsa / Advaita Vedanta	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	= 6

^
 |
 CARVAKA SITS AT THE MINIMUM OF THE LEDGER.
 Everything else in the system follows from that single cell.

△ Caption. This ledger is worth reproducing from memory in any pramāṇa question in Paper I. It shows at a glance that the Cārvāka position is not an eccentric outlier but the lower bound of a shared Indian debate about how many independent sources of knowledge there are. Nyāya sits at four; Cārvāka drives the number down to one and forces every other school to justify its additions.

1. The core thesis, stated exactly

✓ Thesis (pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda). Perception alone is a pramāṇa — an independent, dependable source of valid knowledge (pramā).

✓ Chatterjee and Datta frame the architecture of the whole system on this thesis: "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend logically on their epistemology." Every later denial — of soul, God, karma, rebirth, heaven and liberation — is a consequence drawn from this one epistemic restriction, not a separate act of unbelief.

✓ The vocabulary must be precise:

Term	Meaning	Why the exam cares
Pramā	Valid cognition; knowledge of reality	The thing to be explained
Pramāṇa	The means by which pramā arises	The disputed list
Pratyakṣa	Perception	The only item Cārvāka admits
Anumāna	Inference	Rejected as uncertain
Śabda	Verbal testimony, including scripture	Rejected as derivative
Upamāna	Comparison / analogy	Rejected with the rest

△ The condition Cārvāka imposes. Chatterjee and Datta state it as a conditional test: "If inference is to be regarded as a pramāṇa, it must yield knowledge about which we can have no doubt and which must be true to reality." Note the strength of the demand. This is not "usually reliable"; it is indubitability plus correspondence. Every subsequent Cārvāka argument is an application of this standard.

2. Two kinds of perception, and why the Cārvāka needs both

✓ Cārvāka accepts perception in both its classical forms, and the second is often forgotten by candidates:

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PRATYAKSA
|
+--- BAHYA (external) : through the five external senses --
|   sight, hearing, touch, taste, smell                       |
|                                                                 | > both admitted
+--- ANTARA / MANASA (internal) : the mind's immediate        |
|   awareness of pleasure, pain, desire, and                  |
|   consciousness itself                                     -----
  
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✓ This is not a decorative detail. Chatterjee and Datta present the strongest objection to Cārvāka materialism precisely through internal perception: "do we not have a kind of perception, called internal, which gives an immediate knowledge of our mental states? And do we not perceive in these consciousness which is nowhere to be perceived in the external material objects?" The objector's aim is to force the admission of an immaterial substrate.

✓ The Cārvāka answer, and it is subtle. "The Cārvākas admit that the existence of consciousness is proved by perception. But they deny that consciousness is the quality of any unperceived non-material or spiritual entity." Consciousness is given; a soul is not given. What internal perception delivers is a state of the living body, not evidence of a separate substance.

⚠ Exam-critical inference. Cārvāka is therefore not a denier of consciousness. It is a denier of the inference from consciousness to an immaterial bearer of consciousness. A script that writes "Cārvāka denies consciousness" has confused materialism with eliminativism and has thrown away the 2024 twenty-marker.

3. Certainty versus practical belief — the distinction that saves the position

⚠ The most common failure in this topic is to write that "Cārvāka says nobody ever infers anything." That is not the doctrine, and the texts themselves block it.

✓ Chatterjee and Datta record the Cārvāka's own concession: "It is true that in life we very often act unsuspectingly on inference. But that only shows that we act uncritically on the wrong belief that our inference is true. It is a fact that sometimes our inference comes true and leads to successful results. But it is also a fact that sometimes inference leads to error as well. Truth is not then an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an accident, and a separable one, that we find only in some inferences."

⚠ Unpack that last sentence, because it is the philosophical hinge of the whole topic.

For inference to be a PRAMANA, truth would have to be an
ESSENTIAL and INSEPARABLE character of the inferential process.

But truth attaches to SOME inferences and not to others.

=> truth is ACCIDENTAL (agantuka) to inference, and SEPARABLE from it.

=> inference is not a truth-GUARANTEERING instrument.

...and yet people go on inferring, and often succeed.
The Carvaka does not deny THAT. He denies that success confers
PRAMANA-STATUS.

✓ The authored knowledge file records the same distinction under the heading lokasiddha or laukika inference: practical, corrigible, worldly inference tied to future perceptual confirmation is tolerated; transcendental inference — from ritual to unseen merit, from world to God, from body to soul — is the real target, because nothing could ever check it perceptually.

Axis	Everyday (laukika / vyāvahārika) inference	Transcendental (alaukika / pāramārthika) inference
Example	Smoke on a hill, so probably fire; dark clouds, so probably rain	Ritual now, so heaven later; world exists, so God made it
Corrigibility	✓ Can be checked by later perception	⚠ In principle uncheckable
Cārvāka attitude	⚠ Tolerated as practical habit; denied pramāṇa-status	✓ Rejected outright
What the exam wants	The distinction stated in one sentence	The target of the critique identified correctly

4. Why śabda falls — the argument in five steps

✓ Chatterjee and Datta give a compact and precise argument, worth reproducing as numbered steps:

1. Testimony consists of words (śabda). Insofar as words are heard through our ears, they are perceived — and knowledge of words is therefore perceptual and quite valid.
2. But insofar as those words suggest or mean things not within our perception, and aim at giving knowledge of unperceived objects, "they are not free from error and doubt."
3. Reliance on an authority always proceeds through a suppressed inference. The believer's mind runs: "This authority should be accepted because it is reliable, and all reliable authority should be accepted."

4. That is an inference. "Being based on inference, knowledge derived from verbal testimony or authority is as precarious as inference."

5. Therefore testimony is not an independent source of knowledge.

✓ The special case of the Veda. Chatterjee and Datta report the Cārvāka verdict without softening: "The authority of the Vedas ... is held in high esteem by many. But in reality the Vedas are the works of some cunning priests who earned their living by duping the ignorant and the credulous. With false hopes and promises the Vedas persuade men to perform Vedic rites, the only tangible benefit of which goes to the priests who officiate and enjoy the emoluments."

⚠ Two distinctions to keep clean.

(1) WORDS AS SOUNDS : perceived, and therefore fine.
WORDS AS EVIDENCE : not perceived, and therefore suspect.

(2) REJECTING TESTIMONY $\neq$ REJECTING COMMUNICATION.
Language can guide action; it cannot CERTIFY what it reports until perception catches up with it.

✓ Sharma adds the reinforcing point that testimony cannot be used to rescue inference either: "if testimony proves vyāpti, inference would become dependent on testimony, and then none would be able to infer anything by himself." That reductio is worth a line in any answer on the rejection of inference.

5. Why upamāna, arthāpatti and anupalabdhi fall too

⚠ Cārvāka's argument is a single template applied repeatedly, and stating the template is more impressive than listing the pramāṇas.

Pramāṇa	Its claim	The Cārvāka template applied
Upamāna (Nyāya)	From "the gavaya resembles the cow" plus later sight of the animal, one knows the word's referent	⚠ The similarity is perceived; the linkage of name to kind is a generalisation reaching beyond what is perceived, hence inferential and insecure
Arthāpatti (Mīmāṃsā)	Devadatta is fat, yet does not eat by day; therefore he eats by night	⚠ A postulation to remove an inconsistency — but the postulated fact is unperceived, and the necessity of the postulation is itself a generalisation
Anupalabdhi (Bhāṭṭa, Advaita)	Non-apprehension of the jar yields knowledge of its absence	⚠ Requires the rule "if it existed here it would have been perceived", which is a universal not given in any single perception

⚠ The template in one line, for the answer script: every candidate pramāṇa other than perception depends on a universal proposition, and no universal proposition is perceived. That single sentence disposes of the whole list and shows the examiner you understand the structure rather than the catalogue.

6. What the position buys, and what it costs

	Strength ✓	Cost ⚠
Epistemic	An austere, honest criterion; no unfalsifiable postulates	Knowledge shrinks to the present-and-perceived; science and history become impossible as knowledge
Ontological	No inflated metaphysics; explanatory economy	Cannot account for micro-entities, other minds or the past
Religious	Immunity to priestly manipulation and unverifiable promises	Loses any account of moral order beyond prudence
Dialectical	Forces every rival to justify each additional pramāṇa	Invites the self-refutation charge (Subtopic 3)



Advanced refinement

⚠ Cārvāka's scepticism is selective, and Sharma turns that selectivity into an objection. Śūnyavāda Buddhism and Advaita Vedānta also reject the ultimate validity of inference — but, as Sharma notes, "the Śūnyavādin and the Advaitin reject the ultimate validity of all means of knowledge as such including perception, though they insist on the empirical validity of all means of knowledge. The distinction between ultimate and empirical knowledge is unknown to the Cārvāka. To accept the validity of perception and, at the same time and from the same standpoint, to reject the validity of inference is a thoughtless self-contradiction."

⚠ This gives you a three-way comparison that very few candidates will produce:

School	Perception	Inference	Level-distinction available?
Cārvāka	✓ Valid, full stop	✗ Rejected, full stop	✗ None — hence Sharma's charge of "same standpoint" inconsistency
Śūnyavāda	⚠ Empirically valid, ultimately not	⚠ Empirically valid, ultimately not	✓ Saṃvṛti / paramārtha
Advaita	⚠ Vyāvahārika validity only	⚠ Vyāvahārika validity only	✓ Vyāvahārika / pāramārthika

⚠ The Cārvāka's best available repair, and you should offer it before evaluating: adopt the level-distinction. If the Cārvāka says "inference has vyāvahārika usefulness but no pāramārthika validity", Sharma's charge of same-standpoint inconsistency loses its grip — at the price of conceding that the doctrine is a thesis about certainty rather than about usability. That is precisely the softened reading defended in Subtopic 3.

🔗 Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

🔗 The Cārvāka analysis of śabda — that a hearer's acceptance of testimony always runs through a suppressed premise about the speaker's reliability — is the ancestor of the modern reductionist position in the epistemology of testimony, and it is the exact point at issue in contemporary debates about credibility and misinformation. ⚠ Label it as a conceptual parallel in a single clause if at all; do not import modern examples into a Paper I answer in place of pratyakṣa, anumāna and śabda, and do not present it as a dated event.

UPSC traps

- ⚠ Do not write "Cārvāka accepts only perception and ordinary experience" as if these were two things. Ordinary experience is admitted as perception.
- ✓ Do not forget internal perception. Its admission is what makes Cārvāka a materialist about consciousness rather than a denier of consciousness.
- ⚠ Do not say Cārvāka rejects language or communication. It rejects testimony's claim to independent pramāṇa-status.
- ⚠ Do not list the rejected pramāṇas without giving the single template that rejects them all: each rests on an unperceived universal.
- ⚠ Do not attribute the vyāvahārika / pāramārthika level-distinction to Cārvāka as a historical doctrine. Sharma's point is precisely that Cārvāka lacks it; offering it is a philosophical repair, and it must be labelled as such.
- ⚠ Do not confuse the Cārvāka's demand ("no doubt whatever, and true to reality") with modern fallibilist standards. The strength of the demand is what drives the entire critique.
- ⚠ Do not say the Vedas are rejected "because they are old" or "because they are religious". They are rejected because their authority cannot be perceptually certified and their content promises the unperceivable.

Revision notes

- ✓ Pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda: perception alone is a pramāṇa; everything else in the system follows logically from this.
- ✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend logically on their epistemology."
- ✓ The Cārvāka's test for pramāṇa-hood: knowledge "about which we can have no doubt" and "which must be true to reality".

- ✓ Both external and internal perception are admitted; consciousness is perceived, an immaterial soul is not.
- ✓ Cārvāka denies the inference from consciousness to a soul, not consciousness itself.
- ✓ "Truth is not an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an accident, and a separable one."
- ⚠ Distinguish laukika (corrigible, practical) from pāramārthika (uncheckable, transcendental) inference; the second is the real target.
- ✓ Śabda in five steps: words heard are perceived → what they mean is unperceived → acceptance runs through a reliability inference → inference is precarious → testimony is not independent.
- ✓ Sharma's reductio: if testimony proved vyāpti, "none would be able to infer anything by himself".
- ✓ The Veda is rejected as the work of "cunning priests" whose promises benefit only the officiants — an epistemic charge with a sociological edge.
- ⚠ The single template that kills upamāna, arthāpatti and anupalabdhi: each needs an unperceived universal.
- ⚠ Sharma's charge: Cārvāka accepts perception and rejects inference from the same standpoint, lacking the saṃvṛti/paramārtha or vyāvahārika/pāramārthika distinction that saves Śūnyavāda and Advaita.

MCQ 3

The Cārvāka admits internal perception (mānasa-pratyakṣa) and grants that consciousness is established by it. Which conclusion does the Cārvāka draw, and which does he refuse to draw?

- A. He draws the conclusion that consciousness is unreal, and refuses the conclusion that the body exists.
- B. He draws the conclusion that inference is valid within the mental domain, and refuses to extend it to external objects.
- C. He draws the conclusion that consciousness exists as a perceived fact of the living body, and refuses the further inference that consciousness must be the quality of an unperceived non-material substance.
- D. He draws the conclusion that the soul is perceived directly, and refuses only the claim that it is eternal.

✓ Correct answer: C. Chatterjee and Datta put it exactly: "The Cārvākas admit that the existence of consciousness is proved by perception. But they deny that consciousness is the quality of any unperceived non-material or spiritual entity." A makes Cārvāka an eliminativist, which he is not; B invents a domain-restricted acceptance of inference found nowhere in the sources; D contradicts the school's core denial of ātman.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 4

Consider the Cārvāka's argument against śabda as an independent pramāṇa. Which statement best captures its logical structure?

- A. Words are unreal, therefore what they express is unreal.
- B. Scripture is composed by human beings, therefore all its statements are false.
- C. Testimony is valid only when the speaker is a ṛṣi, and no ṛṣi can be perceived today.
- D. Hearing a word is perceptual and therefore valid, but moving from the word to the unperceived object it reports requires the suppressed premise that reliable authority should be accepted — which is an inference, and inference is itself unproved.

✓ Correct answer: D. This reproduces the argument in Chatterjee and Datta: knowledge of words is perceptual and "quite valid", but insofar as words "suggest or mean things not within our perception ... they are not free from error and doubt", and the belief in the authority is "generated by a mental process" that is plainly inferential — hence testimony is "as precarious as inference". A misstates the position, since words are perceived and real. B is a non sequitur that no Cārvāka source asserts in that form. C invents a condition of reliability that the Cārvāka never accepts.

✓ Subtopic 2 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now state the sole-pramāṇa thesis, defend the admission of internal perception, separate certainty from practical belief, and dispatch śabda and the remaining pramāṇas with one template. Proceeding to the critique of inference itself.

Progress: 3 / 9 | Stage: Core | Subtopic: The Critique of Inference — Vyāpti, Upādhi, the Socrates Syllogism and Self-Refutation

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

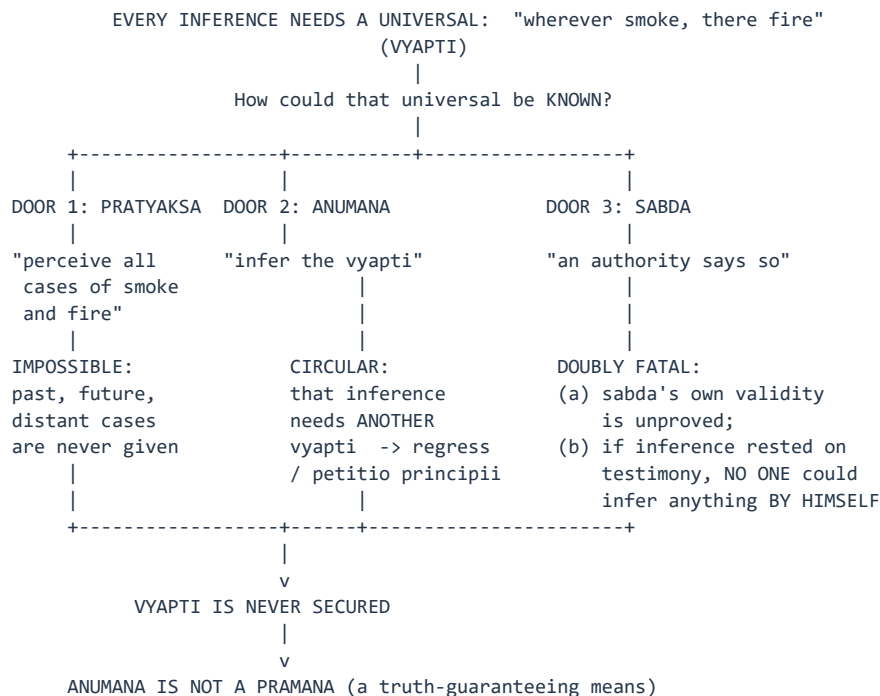
📖 Book context: Carvaka.md §1.2, §1.3, §1.6 and §1.7 read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §II.1 ("Inference is not Certain") — including the sāmānya / class-character objection and the upādhi of wet fuel — read directly from the local OCR-searchable copy; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §III, on deduction as petitio principii and induction as an unwarranted leap, read directly; _PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md consulted for the exact 2019 Q6(c) and 2025 Q5(a) wording.

🔍 CA Search: "problem of induction, inference under uncertainty, Cārvāka anumāna — developments February–August 2026"

📅 CA Found: None in last 6 months. No credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. 🔗 The perennial problem of induction and modern reasoning under uncertainty are flagged at the end as clearly labelled conceptual parallels only.



VISUAL — The three-door trap: how vyāpti is cornered



⚠️ Caption. Draw this in the answer booklet. Three doors, all shut — that is the entire 2025 ten-marker, and the spine of the 2018, 2019 and 2022 questions. Notice that Door 3 is shut twice, and the second bolt (Sharma's "none would be able to infer anything by himself") is the one most candidates miss.

1. The doctrine, stated exactly

✓ Thesis. Anumāna is not a pramāṇa, because inference is "a mere leap in the dark" (Sharma): we proceed from the known to the unknown, and there is no certainty in this, "though some inferences may turn out to be accidentally true."

✓ The structural point. Inference is a movement from a perceived mark (liṅga, e.g. smoke) to an unperceived sādhyā (e.g. fire), licensed by an invariable concomitance (vyāpti) between them. Chatterjee and Datta present the Naiyāyika's own fuller statement of the inference — "all cases of smoke are cases of fire; this mountain is a case of smoke; therefore this is a case of fire" — and then locate the Cārvāka attack precisely: the argument "would be acceptable only if the major premise, stating the invariable relation between the middle term and the major, were beyond doubt."

⚠️ The move to memorise. The Cārvāka never attacks the form of the inference. He grants that if the major premise were secure the conclusion would follow. He attacks the licence — the universal proposition that makes the movement

legitimate. This is why the correct one-line statement of the doctrine is: the Cārvāka critique of inference is a critique of the grounding of vyāpti, not of syllogistic validity.

2. Door 1 — vyāpti cannot be established by perception

✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "this invariable relation (vyāpti) can be established only if we have a knowledge of all cases of smoke and presence of fire. This, however, is not possible, as we cannot perceive even all the cases of smoke and fire existing now in different parts of the world, to speak nothing of those which existed in the past or will exist in the future."

OBSERVED SET		UNIVERSAL CLAIMED
-----		-----
[kitchen fire]		ALL smoke, everywhere,
[hill fire]	---- ? ---->	at every time, past,
[hearth fire]		present and future
[...n cases]		
finite, present,		infinite, temporally
local, contingent		unbounded, exceptionless
+--> the gap here is not a gap of DEGREE. It is a gap of KIND.		

✓ The class-character (sāmānya) rejoinder, and the Cārvāka's answer. This is the sharpest exchange in the topic and almost no candidate reproduces it. The Naiyāyika-style objector says: granted we cannot perceive all individual smokes, but can we not perceive the class-characters "smokeness" (dhūmatva) and "fireness" (vahnitva), and perceive a relation between the universals, and thereby license the inference?

✓ Chatterjee and Datta record the Cārvāka's two-part reply verbatim in substance:

1. Even granting perception of a relation between smokeness and fireness, "we cannot know therefrom any invariable relation between all individual cases of smoke and fire. To be able to infer a particular fire, we must know that it is inseparably related to the particular smoke perceived."
2. Worse, "it is not possible even to know by perception what 'smokeness' ... is, because we do not perceive all cases of smoke."

⚠ What this exchange really shows. The Cārvāka refuses to let the Naiyāyika escape the particular–universal gap by relocating it in the universals: the same finitude that blocks the enumeration of instances blocks the perceptual grasp of the class-character. Chatterjee and Datta conclude for him: "the difficulty of passing from particulars to the universal, therefore, remains here as before."

3. Door 2 — vyāpti cannot be established by inference

✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "Neither can it be said to be based on another inference, because it will involve a petitio principii, since the validity of that inference again has to be similarly proved."

✓ Sharma sharpens the same point into a pair:

DEDUCTION	: "All men are mortal; Socrates is a man; so Socrates is mortal." The conclusion is ALREADY CONTAINED in the major premise. => petitio principii, an argument in a circle.
INDUCTION	: offered to establish the major premise. But induction "proceeds unwarrantedly from the known to the unknown." => the major premise is never secured.
RESULT	: "Induction is uncertain and deduction is argument in a circle. The logicians, therefore, find themselves stuck up in the mud of inference." (Sharma, quoting the Carvaka gibe)

⚠ Why this is not merely a dilemma but a trap. Each horn is repaired only by the other. Deduction's circularity is cured by grounding the major premise inductively; induction's insecurity is cured by grounding it deductively. The Cārvāka's point is that the two cures are the same wound seen from two directions.

✓ Chatterjee and Datta add the causal variant, which candidates often think is a way out: "can we not base our knowledge of the invariable relation between smoke and fire on a causal relation between them?" The Cārvāka reply: "a causal relation, being only a kind of invariable relation, cannot be established by perception owing to the same difficulties."

4. Door 3 — vyāpti cannot be established by testimony

✓ Two independent bolts, and both should appear in a 15-marker:

- ✓ "Nor can this vyāpti be based on the testimony (śabda) of reliable persons ... For, the validity of testimony itself requires to be proved by inference" (Chatterjee and Datta). Grounding inference in testimony and testimony in inference is a closed circle.
- ✓ "Besides, if inference always depended on testimony, no one could infer anything by himself" (Chatterjee and Datta; Sharma states the same reductio). Inference is manifestly a first-person cognitive capacity; making it parasitic on the word of another misdescribes what inference is.

5. The upādhi problem — the deepest cut

✓ Statement. Even where two things are repeatedly observed together, an unnoticed condition (upādhi) may be doing the work; so observed constancy never establishes unconditional concomitance.

✓ The textbook example, exactly as Chatterjee and Datta give it — and note that it runs in the direction most candidates get backwards:

```
A man perceives fire accompanied by smoke, many times.
On another occasion he perceives FIRE and infers SMOKE.
                                ^^^^          ^^^^^
He is liable to ERROR.
Why? Because he failed to notice a CONDITION (upadhi):
WETNESS OF FUEL -- on the presence of which ALONE fire is
attended with smoke.
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The relation "fire -> smoke" holds only ARDRENDHANA-SAMYOGA-SAHITE,
i.e. where fire is joined with wet fuel. A red-hot iron ball is
fire WITHOUT smoke.
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✓ Chatterjee and Datta draw the general conclusion: "So long as the relation between two phenomena is not proved to be unconditional, it is an uncertain ground for inference. And unconditionality or absence of conditions cannot be established beyond doubt by perception, as some conditions may always remain hidden and escape notice. Inference or testimony cannot be used for proving this unconditionality without a petitio principii, because its validity also is being questioned here."

⚠ Why the upādhi argument is stronger than the enumeration argument. The enumeration argument says: you have not checked enough cases. The upādhi argument says: even if you had checked every case you can check, you could not know that you had identified the right property as the ground of the relation. The first is a problem of quantity; the second is a problem of the identification of the relevant variable. Nyāya can answer the first with more observation. It cannot answer the second with more observation alone — which is why it must bring in tarka (Subtopic 4).

6. Solved PYQ — 2019, Q6(c), 15 marks: the Socrates syllogism

✓ Exact question. "What is wrong according to the Cārvākas with the following argument? All men are mortal. Socrates is a man. Therefore, Socrates is mortal. Justify your answer with arguments."

⚠ What the question is really testing. Whether the candidate can apply the vyāpti critique to a deductive syllogism rather than reciting the smoke-and-fire example. The examiner has deliberately chosen a Western textbook syllogism whose validity is not in dispute, in order to see whether the candidate attacks the right thing.

⚠ Model answer (≈245 words).

The Cārvāka objection is not that the argument is formally invalid. If the premises hold, the conclusion follows. The objection is directed at the major premise, "All men are mortal", which functions here exactly as vyāpti does in Indian inference — an invariable, exceptionless concomitance between man-ness and mortality.

How is that universal known? Not by perception: no one has perceived all men — past, present, future, near and distant. Chatterjee and Datta press exactly this point: we cannot perceive even all present cases, "to speak nothing of those which existed in the past or will exist in the future." Not by inference: any inference to the universal would itself require a further universal, generating a petitio principii or a regress. Not by testimony: testimony's own validity is established only inferentially, and if inference depended on testimony "no one could infer anything by himself."

Hence the syllogism is, in Sharma's formulation, an argument in a circle: "Socrates is mortal" is already contained in "All men are mortal." The deduction merely extracts what induction failed to establish. And upādhi deepens the objection:

perhaps what is genuinely invariable is not man-ness with mortality but embodiment-with-organic-decay under conditions never fully surveyed.

Verdict. ⚠ The Cārvāka charge is that the syllogism is valid but epistemically empty: it transmits a certainty in the major premise that was never independently acquired. That is a serious charge about induction, though the Cārvāka must still answer how his own universal denial of inference is known.

⚠ The four things this answer must contain, and no answer without them scores well: (i) explicit refusal to attack validity; (ii) the major premise identified as vyāpti; (iii) the three-door argument applied; (iv) the petitio principii formulation of deduction plus one line of self-critical balance.

7. The self-refutation charge (2018, 2019, 2022) — and the Cārvāka's replies

✓ The charge, in its strongest form. Sharma states it without mercy: "To refuse the validity of inference from the empirical standpoint is to refuse to think and discuss. All thoughts, all discussions, all doctrines, all affirmations and denials, all proofs and disproofs are made possible by inference. The Cārvāka view that perception is valid and inference is invalid is itself a result of inference. The Cārvāka can understand others only through inference and make others understand him only through inference. Thoughts and ideas, not being material objects, cannot be perceived; they can only be inferred. Hence the self-refuted Cārvāka position is called sheer nonsense and no system of philosophy."

⚠ Reconstructed as numbered steps, because the examiner wants the logic and not the invective:

1. The Carvaka asserts: "No inference is a valid source of knowledge."
2. That assertion is UNIVERSAL. It quantifies over all inferential acts, past, present and future.
3. No universal proposition is given in any single perception.
4. Therefore the thesis is either (a) itself inferential -- and so self-defeating -- or (b) not knowledge by its own standard.
5. Further: to REFUTE Nyaya, the Carvaka must reason. To be UNDERSTOOD, he must rely on his hearers inferring his meaning from his words.
6. Further still: other MINDS are never perceived. The Carvaka's very act of arguing with an opponent presupposes an inference to another mind.

⚠ The Cārvāka's three available replies — a strong answer gives all three and grades them.

Reply	Formulation	Assessment
R1 — The "no thesis" or vitanḍā reply	The Cārvāka advances no positive doctrine; he only destroys the opponent's claim to certainty, using the opponent's own standards. A purely destructive dialectic incurs no commitments.	⚠ Coherent, but it converts Cārvāka from a philosophy into a method — and Cārvāka does assert four elements, a body-self and kāma as the end, so it cannot be a global reply.
R2 — The softened-thesis reply	The thesis is not "no one ever infers" but "inference never yields apodictic certainty beyond what perception can check". As a claim about certainty rather than usability, it is not refuted by the fact that the Cārvāka reasons.	⚠ The strongest reply. It is the reading the authored knowledge file endorses, and it rescues consistency at the price of weakening the doctrine into radical fallibilism.
R3 — The level-distinction reply	Concede vyāvahārika validity to inference and deny only pāramārthika validity.	⚠ Effective against Sharma's "same standpoint" charge, but the level-distinction is, as Sharma says, "unknown to the Cārvāka" — so it is a repair offered by the interpreter, and must be labelled as such.

⚠ The verdict to write. Against the uncompromising formulation the self-refutation charge is decisive; against the softened formulation it loses its force but so does the doctrine, which becomes a fallibilist warning rather than a denial of a pramāṇa. The Cārvāka can be consistent or radical, but not both. That sentence answers 2019 Q5(c) almost by itself.

8. Sharma's counter-attack on perception — the tu quoque

✓ Sharma turns the Cārvāka's weapon around: "Perception itself which is regarded as valid by the Cārvāka is often found untrue. We perceive the earth as flat but it is almost round. We perceive the earth as static but it is moving round the sun. We perceive the disc of the sun as of a small size, but it is much bigger than the size of the earth. Such perceptual knowledge is contradicted by inference."

✓ And the constructive half, which is really a Kantian point made in an Indian idiom: "pure perception in the sense of mere sensation cannot be regarded as a means of knowledge unless conception or thought has arranged into order and has given meaning and significance to the loose threads of sense-data." Sharma cites the Buddhist *Tattvasaṅgraha* for this line of attack.

△ Why this is devastating and must be handled, not avoided. If perception is fallible and is corrected by inference, then the very hierarchy Cārvāka asserts is inverted: inference becomes the tribunal before which perception is judged. A 15- or 20-mark answer that reproduces the Cārvāka case without meeting this rejoinder is one-sided.

△ Best Cārvāka response available: the errors Sharma lists are corrected by further perception plus practical checking, not by pure inference — and a fallibilist Cārvāka can concede correction within perception while still denying that any unperceivable entity is established by it. That reply is decent for the flat-earth case and weak for the heliocentric case, and you should say so.

Advanced refinement

⚠ Distinguish two Cārvāka claims that are constantly run together in scripts:

CLAIM A (epistemic) : inference does not GUARANTEE truth
-> defensible; almost universally granted today

CLAIM B (semantic/ ontological) : the words "wherever smoke, there fire" express
no knowable proposition at all
-> far stronger; hard to hold while doing philosophy

△ Most of the force of the Cārvāka critique lives in Claim A. Most of the vulnerability to self-refutation lives in Claim B. A first-class answer separates them and says which one it is defending.

△ A further refinement on the target. The Cārvāka's practical inferences are always perceptually redeemable: I infer fire, I climb the hill, I see fire. Transcendental inferences are structurally unredeemable: I infer heaven from agnihotra, and no perception could ever cash the claim. The Cārvāka's position becomes far more defensible when stated as: an inference is worth something to the extent that its conclusion is in principle perceptually checkable — which is a verificationist criterion in Indian dress, and is exactly the material needed for the 2024 "positivism" question.

 Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

☞ The vyāpti argument is a strikingly early and complete statement of what Western philosophy calls the problem of induction: that no finite set of observations entails an unrestricted universal, and that attempts to justify induction inductively are circular. The upādhi argument anticipates the modern problem of confounding variables — the possibility that an observed regularity tracks an unnoticed third factor. △ These are conceptual parallels for one clause of comparative colour, not dated developments, and they must never displace the Indian vocabulary in a Paper I script.

UPSC traps

1.  Do not write that the Cārvāka says the syllogism is invalid. He says the major premise is ungrounded, and that deduction is therefore circular.
2.  Do not give the upādhi example backwards. The standard case is inferring smoke from fire, which fails because the upādhi of wet fuel was unnoticed.
3.  Do not omit the sāmānya / class-character exchange. It is the difference between a textbook answer and a top answer.
4.  Do not present the self-refutation charge without the Cārvāka's replies. A one-sided demolition scores poorly on "critically examine".
5.  Do not claim all inference is literally impossible for the Cārvāka. Distinguish pramāṇa-status from everyday expectation and practical action.
6.  Do not forget Door 3's second bolt: if inference rested on testimony, no one could infer anything by himself.
7.  Do not ignore Sharma's tu quoque about perceptual error. Meeting it is what "critically evaluate" means.
8.  Do not treat the causal-relation escape as untouched. A causal relation is itself a species of invariable relation and inherits the same problem.

Revision notes

- ✓ Inference is "a leap in the dark"; some inferences are true only "accidentally".
- ✓ The attack is on the major premise (vyāpti), never on syllogistic form.
- ✓ Door 1 (perception): all cases past, present and future can never be surveyed.
- ✓ Class-character reply: even dhūmatva and vahnitva cannot be perceptually known, since all instances are not perceived; and universal-to-universal relation does not license a particular-to-particular inference.
- ✓ Door 2 (inference): petitio principii or infinite regress; deduction is circular, induction unwarranted.
- ✓ Causal relation is only a species of invariable relation and inherits the same defect.
- ✓ Door 3 (testimony): testimony's validity is itself inferred; and "if inference always depended on testimony, no one could infer anything by himself."
- ✓ Upādhi: the wet-fuel condition; unconditionality can never be perceptually certified because conditions may remain hidden.
- ✓ Upādhi is a problem of the right variable, not merely of sample size — which is why more observation alone cannot answer it.
- ✓ Self-refutation: the universal denial of inference is itself a universal; and other minds, thoughts and ideas are never perceived.
- ⚠ Three replies: no-thesis (vitaṇḍā) · softened certainty-thesis · level-distinction. The second is strongest; the third is a repair, not a historical doctrine.
- ⚠ Sharma's tu quoque: flat earth, static earth, small sun — perception errs and is corrected by inference.
- ⚠ Verdict formula: the Cārvāka may be consistent or radical, but not both.

MCQ 5

According to the standard Cārvāka critique, what exactly is defective in the argument "All men are mortal; Socrates is a man; therefore Socrates is mortal"?

- A. Nothing in its form, but the major premise states an unrestricted universal that cannot be established by perception, cannot be established by a further inference without circularity, and cannot be established by testimony — so the deduction merely re-states an unwarranted assumption.
- B. The middle term is undistributed, which makes the syllogism formally invalid.
- C. The conclusion asserts a future event, and no proposition about the future can be meaningful.
- D. Socrates is not perceived by the speaker, so no proposition about him can be entertained at all.

✓ Correct answer: A. The Cārvāka grants formal validity and attacks the grounding of the universal, exactly as with vyāpti; Sharma adds that the conclusion is "already contained in the major premise", making the deduction a petitio principii. B misdescribes a valid Barbara syllogism. C imports a verificationist thesis about future-tensed statements that the Cārvāka never advances in this form. D would abolish testimony-based reference altogether, which even the Cārvāka does not do — he allows words as perceived sounds.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 6

Which of the following best explains why the upādhi objection is philosophically deeper than the objection from incomplete enumeration?

- A. Because upādhi shows that the observed cases were fabricated.
- B. Because incomplete enumeration is a defect of sample size, curable in principle by further observation, whereas upādhi shows that even exhaustively observed regularity may track an unnoticed condition — so the identification of the relevant ground of the relation, not merely the number of cases, is what remains uncertified.
- C. Because upādhi proves that causal relations do not exist.
- D. Because upādhi applies only to inference from effect to cause, which is the only kind of inference the Cārvāka rejects.

✓ Correct answer: B. Chatterjee and Datta make the crucial point that "unconditionality or absence of conditions cannot be established beyond doubt by perception, as some conditions may always remain hidden and escape notice" — a defect that further counting cannot cure, and the reason Nyāya must introduce tarka rather than merely more observation. A misdescribes the argument, which concedes the observations. C overstates: the objection is epistemic, not a denial of causation as such. D invents a restriction found in no source; the Cārvāka's target is inference in general, and most sharply transcendental inference.

✓ Subtopic 3 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now run the three-door argument, deploy upādhi correctly, answer the Socrates question, and both press and rebut the self-refutation charge. Proceeding to the Nyāya defence, without which no "critically examine" answer is complete.

Progress: 4 / 9 | Stage: Core | Subtopic: The Nyāya Defence of Inference — and a Critically Balanced Verdict

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

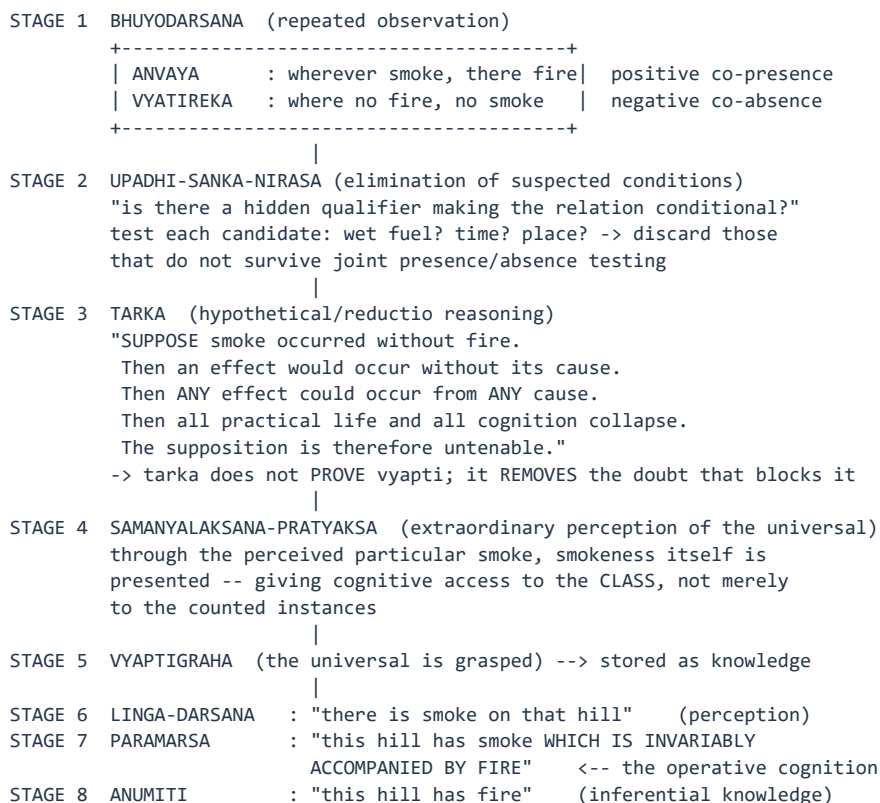
📖 Book context: Carvaka.md §1.5 and §3.1 read in full; paper-1/indian/Nyaya-Vaisesika.md §§ on vyāpti, bhūyodarśana, tarka, upādhi-elimination and sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa, plus §11.2 on the Naiyāyika response to Cārvāka, read directly; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §III, on the Nyāya-side counter-attack including the Tattvasaṅgraha point about sensation requiring conception, read directly; _PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md consulted for 2018 Q8(b) and the cross-linked 2022 Q7(c).

🔍 CA Search: "Nyāya theory of inference, vyāpti and tarka — scholarly developments February–August 2026"

📅 CA Found: None in last 6 months. No credible, dated Cārvāka- or anumāna-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. 🔗 A labelled conceptual parallel to modern accounts of inference under uncertainty is noted at the end and carries no evidential weight.



VISUAL — How Nyāya actually builds a vyāpti, step by step



⚠️ Caption. The Cārvāka argues as if vyāpti had to be acquired in one impossible act of total enumeration. Nyāya's reply is architectural: vyāpti is assembled through five distinguishable operations, and the burden of certainty is distributed across them. Reproducing this eight-stage ladder is the single most effective way to show an examiner that

you understand what Cārvāka is actually up against.

1. Why Nyāya cannot simply concede

△ Nyāya is the school of pramāṇa-theory. If inference falls, then upamāna falls with it, śabda loses its warrant, the proofs of God (kāryāt, āyojanāt, dhr̥tyādeḥ, padāt/śruteḥ) collapse, the atomic theory becomes unstateable, and the Nyāya proofs of the self go with them. The Cārvāka attack is therefore not a peripheral irritant but an existential threat, which is why the Naiyāyika reply is so highly developed.

2. Anvaya and vyatireka — the joint method

✓ The doctrine. Vyāpti is established by bhūyodarśana, repeated observation, but of a particular disciplined kind:

Method	Sanskrit	Form	Function
Method of agreement	anvaya	Wherever hetu, there sādhyā	Establishes positive co-presence across varied cases
Method of difference	vyatireka	Wherever sādhyā is absent, hetu is absent	Rules out cases where the mark occurs without the probandum
Joint method	anvaya-vyatireka	Both together	The absence of a single counter-instance across wide, varied observation

△ The philosophical point to make explicit. The Cārvāka treats repeated observation as mere counting. Nyāya treats it as structured testing: it is not the number of positive cases that matters but the survival of the relation through deliberate search for negative cases. A relation that survives systematic attempts to find hetu-without-sādhyā has a warrant that a mere tally does not.

3. Upādhi-elimination — meeting the Cārvāka's strongest weapon

✓ The Nyāya procedure. An upādhi is defined technically as a condition that pervades the sādhyā but does not pervade the hetu. To test a suspected relation, the Naiyāyika asks whether any such condition can be found; where one is found, the vyāpti is reformulated to include it.

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BAD VYAPTI : "wherever fire, there smoke"
UPADHI FOUND: wet fuel (ardra-indhana)
REPAIR      : "wherever fire joined with wet fuel, there smoke"
RESULT      : the conditional relation is not abandoned -- it is
               RESTATED at the correct level of generality.

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△ The concession Nyāya must make, and an honest answer states it. Nyāya can eliminate suspected and known upādhis. It cannot demonstrate that no upādhi whatever remains undetected. What it claims instead is that a relation which survives systematic testing, negative-case search and tarka is rationally warranted, not that it is guaranteed by an omniscient survey.

△ The move that decides the debate. Nyāya shifts the standard from impossible omniscience to disciplined rational warrant. The Cārvāka has set a bar — indubitability plus correspondence — that nothing except present perception could clear, and even present perception clears it only if perceptual error is ignored. Nyāya's reply is that this bar is not a criterion of knowledge but a recipe for its abolition.

4. Tarka — the argument the Cārvāka has no answer to

✓ What tarka is. Tarka is hypothetical reasoning, reductio ad absurdum: it assumes the contradictory of the proposed relation and exhibits the unacceptable consequence. It is expressly not an independent pramāṇa in Nyāya; it is a pramāṇa-anugrahaka — an auxiliary that removes doubt so that vyāptigraha can occur.

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SUPPOSE : smoke without fire
THEN     : an effect exists without its cause
THEN     : the causal order is arbitrary
THEN     : no expectation, no action, no discourse, no refutation
BUT      : the Carvaka HIMSELF acts, expects, argues and refutes
THEREFORE: the supposition is untenable (anista-prasanga)

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△ Why this is so powerful against Cārvāka specifically. The Cārvāka concedes that people act on inference and that action often succeeds. Tarka converts that concession into a premise: the intelligibility of the Cārvāka's own practice — including the practice of arguing against Nyāya — presupposes the very regularities he refuses to certify. The Cārvāka can escape only by retreating to the softened thesis (Subtopic 3, reply R2), at which point the dispute becomes verbal rather than doctrinal.

5. Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa — Nyāya's direct answer to the class-character objection

✓ The doctrine. Nyāya admits an extraordinary (alaukika) perception in which, through a perceived particular, the universal itself is presented — smokeness through this smoke. The authored Nyāya file records the trap explicitly: it is an error to say that universals are not perceived in Nyāya; they are, through sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa.

△ The exchange, laid out for the answer script:

Move	Claim
Cārvāka	✓ You cannot perceive all smokes; therefore you cannot perceive smokeness; therefore you have no universal
Nyāya	✓ The universal is not reached by adding up particulars; it is presented in any particular through extraordinary perception
Cārvāka rejoinder	△ Sāmānyalakṣaṇa is a technical device invented precisely to plug the hole; it is theory-laden, not independently attested
Assessment	△ Honest verdict: the device does real work inside Nyāya's realism about universals, but it will not convince anyone who does not already accept that realism. The debate here bottoms out in ontology, not in epistemology

6. Parāmarśa — what actually generates the inferential cognition

✓ The doctrine. In Nyāya, inferential knowledge (anumiti) is produced by a specific operative cognition (karaṇa) called parāmarśa: the cognition of the mark as qualified by its invariable concomitance — "this hill possesses smoke, which is invariably accompanied by fire."

△ Why this matters against Cārvāka. The Cārvāka pictures inference as a leap across a gap: from perceived smoke, jump to unperceived fire. Nyāya's analysis denies that there is any leap at all. What produces the conclusion is a single complex cognition in which the mark is already apprehended under the concomitance. There is no moment at which the mind is stranded between premises with a chasm to cross.

△ A memorable line for the answer: For Cārvāka, inference is a jump in the dark; for Nyāya, it is a step taken in the light of a concomitance already grasped.

7. The Nyāya counter-attack on perception

✓ Sharma reports this as the decisive counter-move, and it was set out in Subtopic 3 §8: perception itself errs — the flat earth, the static earth, the small solar disc — "such perceptual knowledge is contradicted by inference." And, following the Tattvasaṅgraha, "pure perception in the sense of mere sensation cannot be regarded as a means of knowledge unless conception or thought has arranged into order and has given meaning and significance to the loose threads of sense-data."

△ The structural result, and it is a genuine reversal:

CARVAKA'S PICTURE

perception = certain
inference = derivative

hierarchy: P > I

NYAYA'S CORRECTED PICTURE

perception = fallible, and CORRECTED by inference
inference = the tribunal that corrects perception

hierarchy: neither is self-sufficient;
perception supplies content,
inference supplies order and correction

△ Note the Nyāya distinction that keeps this honest: Nyāya distinguishes nirvikalpaka (indeterminate, pre-predicative) from savikalpaka (determinate, qualified) perception. Only determinate perception is judgemental — and determinate perception already involves conceptual qualification. The Cārvāka's "pure given" is therefore, on the

Nyāya analysis, either pre-cognitive and useless, or already conceptually shaped and therefore not the innocent bedrock he supposes.

8. Solved PYQ material — 2018, Q8(b), 15 marks, and its exact demand

✓ Exact question. "Is Cārvāka rejection of inference acceptable to the other systems of Indian philosophy? If not, why? Do you think the views of other systems to be justified? Give reasons for your answer."

△ The demand has three distinct limbs and candidates routinely answer only the first:

LIMB 1 : IS IT ACCEPTED? → a survey across schools (mostly NO)
 LIMB 2 : IF NOT, WHY NOT? → the reasons, school by school
 LIMB 3 : ARE THEY JUSTIFIED? → the candidate's own graded verdict

△ The cross-school survey table, which is the backbone of Limb 1 and 2:

School	Accepts anumāna?	Its reason for refusing the Cārvāka
Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika	✓ Yes, as an independent pramāṇa	Anvaya-vyatireka + upādhi-elimination + tarka + sāmānyalakṣaṇa; and the denial is itself inferential
Sāṃkhya–Yoga	✓ Yes	Prakṛti, puruṣa and the guṇas are established by inference from perceptible effects; without inference the system cannot begin
Mīmāṃsā	✓ Yes	Ritual injunction and apūrva require inference; and the Cārvāka's attack on śabda strikes at Mīmāṃsā's foundation
Jainism	✓ Yes	Mati and śruta knowledge involve inference; and anekāntavāda requires the very universals Cārvāka denies
Buddhism	✓ Yes (pratyakṣa and anumāna)	Dignāga and Dharmakīrti build an entire logic; and Tattvasaṅgraha attacks Cārvāka's naïve perceptualism directly
Advaita Vedānta	△ Yes at the vyāvahārika level	Rejects ultimate validity of all pramāṇas including perception — a level-distinction Cārvāka lacks

△ Limb 3 — the graded verdict to write. The other systems are justified in rejecting the strong Cārvāka thesis, because a wholesale denial of inference is self-defeating and would abolish the very discourse in which it is stated. They are not entitled to treat the objection as disposed of, because Nyāya's positive account replaces the demand for certainty with a demand for warrant — a substitution that answers the Cārvāka only if fallibilism is accepted, which is itself a concession to him. The correct verdict is therefore that Cārvāka loses the war and wins a battle: inference survives as a pramāṇa, but it survives as a warranted rather than an indubitable one.

Advanced refinement

△ What the debate is really about, stated at the highest level. Both sides agree that finite observation cannot logically entail an unrestricted universal. They disagree about what follows.

CARVAKA : entailment fails => no knowledge => no pramana-status
 NYAYA : entailment fails => but WARRANT does not require entailment
 => disciplined procedure yields knowledge
 => pramana-status is preserved

△ The disagreement is therefore about the concept of knowledge, not about the logic of induction, on which the two are in near-agreement. Writing that sentence identifies the true locus of the dispute and is the mark of a top script.

△ The honest residue against Nyāya, which a balanced answer must supply so as not to look partisan: (i) tarka is admittedly not a pramāṇa and cannot by itself establish anything; (ii) sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa is defensible only inside Nyāya's realism about universals, so it is not a neutral answer; (iii) the elimination of upādhis is always elimination of suspected conditions, never a proof that none remains. Nyāya's inference is therefore highly disciplined but not indefeasible — which is precisely what a fallibilist Cārvāka wanted to hear.

🔗 Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

🔗 Nyāya's replacement of certainty by disciplined warrant, with negative-case testing and the systematic elimination of confounders, is conceptually parallel to modern accounts of inference under uncertainty — controlled comparison, elimination of alternative explanations, and degrees of confirmation rather than proof. ⚠️ Use at most one clause of this in an answer, explicitly as a conceptual analogy, never as a dated development or as authority.

UPSC traps

1. ⚠️ Do not say Nyāya "proves" vyāpti with certainty. It claims disciplined warrant and eliminates suspected conditions.
2. ⚠️ Do not call tarka a pramāṇa. It is pramāṇa-anugrahaka, an auxiliary that removes doubt.
3. ✓ Do not write that Nyāya denies the perception of universals. It affirms it through sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa.
4. ⚠️ Do not omit parāmarśa. Without it, you cannot explain why Nyāya denies that inference is a "leap" at all.
5. ⚠️ Do not answer 2018 Q8(b) with only one school. The question says "the other systems" — plural — and asks for your own verdict as a third limb.
6. ⚠️ Do not present Advaita as agreeing with Cārvāka about inference. Advaita's denial is at the pāramārthika level and applies to perception equally.
7. ⚠️ Do not forget Nyāya's nirvikalpaka / savikalpaka distinction when replying to the "pure given" assumption.

Revision notes

- ✓ Vyāpti is built by bhūyodarśana, disciplined as anvaya (co-presence) and vyatireka (co-absence).
- ✓ Upādhi-elimination repairs a defective universal by restating it at the correct level of generality — "fire with wet fuel, there smoke".
- ✓ Tarka is hypothetical reductio reasoning; it is not a pramāṇa but removes the doubt blocking vyāptigraha.
- ✓ Tarka's force against Cārvāka: his own acting, expecting and arguing presuppose the regularities he refuses to certify.
- ✓ Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa answers the class-character objection by presenting the universal through the particular.
- ✓ Parāmarśa — the cognition of the mark as qualified by concomitance — is the karaṇa of anumiti; hence no "leap".
- ✓ The eight-stage ladder: bhūyodarśana → upādhi-elimination → tarka → sāmānyalakṣaṇa → vyāptigraha → liṅga-darśana → parāmarśa → anumiti.
- ✓ Sharma's counter-attack: perception errs (flat earth, static earth, small sun) and is corrected by inference.
- ✓ Tattvasaṅgraha point: mere sensation is not knowledge until conception orders "the loose threads of sense-data".
- ⚠️ Nyāya's decisive move: replace omniscient certainty with disciplined warrant as the standard for pramāṇa-hood.
- ⚠️ Honest residue: tarka proves nothing alone; sāmānyalakṣaṇa presupposes realism about universals; undetected upādhis cannot be excluded in principle.
- ⚠️ 2018 Q8(b) has three limbs — is it accepted, why not, and are the objectors justified. Answer all three.
- ⚠️ Verdict formula: Cārvāka loses the war and wins a battle — inference survives as warranted, not as indubitable.

MCQ 7

In Nyāya epistemology, what precisely is the role of tarka in establishing vyāpti?

- A. Tarka is a fifth independent pramāṇa, alongside perception, inference, comparison and testimony.
- B. Tarka directly perceives the universal through the particular, and thereby supplies the invariable concomitance.
- C. Tarka is not itself a pramāṇa but an auxiliary (pramāṇa-anugrahaka): by assuming the contradictory of the proposed relation and exhibiting an unacceptable consequence, it removes the doubt that would otherwise block the grasp of vyāpti.
- D. Tarka is the fallacy of the undistributed middle, which Nyāya uses to expose defective inferences.

✓ Correct answer: C. Tarka is hypothetical reductio reasoning that clears doubt so that vyāptigraha can occur; Nyāya explicitly refuses it independent pramāṇa status. A promotes it wrongly to a pramāṇa; B describes sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa, a different device; D confuses a supportive method with a formal fallacy.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 8

A candidate writes: "Nyāya answers the Cārvāka by proving vyāpti with complete certainty through repeated observation." Which correction is philosophically required?

- A. Nyāya abandons vyāpti altogether and grounds inference in scripture.
- B. Repeated observation is irrelevant in Nyāya, which grounds vyāpti solely in tarka.
- C. Nyāya concedes that inference yields only probability, and therefore agrees with the Cārvāka that it is not a pramāṇa.
- D. Nyāya does not claim an omniscient survey of all cases; it builds vyāpti through the joint method of co-presence and co-absence, elimination of suspected upādhis, tarka and sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa, thereby replacing the demand for indubitable certainty with a demand for disciplined rational warrant.

✓ Correct answer: D. The authored Nyāya file states the position exactly: "The Nyāya point is not infallibilism but disciplined justificatory practice." A is false — Nyāya makes inference independent of śabda. B discards bhūyodarśana, which is the first stage of the ladder. C misstates the outcome: Nyāya insists on pramāṇa-status precisely while conceding that certainty is not achieved by enumeration.

✓ Subtopic 4 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now defend inference on Nyāya's behalf, meet the Cārvāka's strongest weapon, and deliver a balanced verdict rather than a partisan one. Proceeding to metaphysics, where the epistemology begins to pay out.

Progress: 5 / 9 | Stage: Core | Subtopic: Metaphysics and Materialism — Four Bhūtas, the Rejection of Ākāśa, and Svabhāvavāda

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

📖 Book context: Carvaka.md §2.1, §2.2, §2.4, §2.6 and the restored 2018/2020 doctrine dossier on ākāśa read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §III ("Metaphysics"), sub-sections 1 ("The World is made of Four Elements") and 3 ("There is no God"), read directly from the local OCR-searchable copy; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §IV ("Metaphysics"), including the transmitted Bṛhaspati sūtras and Sadānanda's fourfold classification in the Vedāntasāra, read directly.

🔍 CA Search: "physicalism, emergent consciousness and material monism — Cārvāka four elements, developments February–August 2026"

📅 CA Found: None in last 6 months. No credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. 🔗 Contemporary physicalism and the debate over emergence are used at the end of this subtopic strictly as labelled conceptual links, not as current affairs.



VISUAL — The elemental ledger, and the one cell that is empty

	PRTHIVI (earth)	AP (water)	TEJAS (fire)	VAYU (air)	AKASA (ether/space)
NYAYA-VAISESIKA	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y (+ kala, dik, atman, manas = 9 dravyas)
SAMKHYA JAINISM	Y (pudgala covers matter)	Y	Y	Y	Y (from tanmatras) Y (akasa is a separate dravya)
MIMAMSA / VEDANTA	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
CARVAKA	Y	Y	Y	Y	-- NO -- ^^^^^^^^ the empty cell that carries the whole epistemology

⚠ Caption. One empty cell, and it is not an accident of cosmology. Ākāśa is refused for exactly the reason inference and testimony are refused: it is not perceived, it is inferred. The elemental ledger is therefore the neatest possible demonstration that Cārvāka metaphysics is epistemology applied. This visual answers the first half of the 2020 fifteen-marker on its own.

1. The bridging principle — ontology follows epistemology

✓ Chatterjee and Datta state the derivation in a single sentence: "The Cārvāka theory of reality follows from the epistemological conclusion just discussed. If perception is the only reliable source of knowledge, we can rationally assert only the reality of perceptible objects. God, soul, heaven, life before birth or after death, and any unperceived law (like *adrṣṭa*) cannot be believed in, because they are all beyond perception."

⚠ The principle, formalised for the answer script:

- P1. Only perception is a pramana. (epistemology)
P2. Ontological commitment should not outrun the reach of the pramanas one accepts. (bridging principle)

C. Only perceptible entities may be admitted as real. (ontology)

⚠ P2 is doing enormous work and is rarely noticed by candidates. It is not a truth of logic. An opponent could accept P1 and yet hold that reality exceeds knowledge — that there are unknowable realities. Cārvāka refuses that gap: for him, what cannot in principle be presented in perception has no claim to be admitted. Naming P2 explicitly, and observing that it is a presupposition rather than a proof, is exactly the kind of move that separates a 60% script from an 80% script.

2. The four bhūtas

✓ The transmitted sūtra: *prthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni* — "earth, water, fire and air are the elements." And the second: *tatsamudāye śarīrendriya-viśaya-saṃjñā* — "bodies, senses and objects" are the results of the different combinations of these elements.

✓ Chatterjee and Datta add the biological consequence explicitly: "Not only non-living material objects but also living organisms, like plants and animal bodies, are composed of these four elements, by the combination of which they are produced and to which they are reduced on death." There is no separate vital principle and no separate psychic substance.

✓ Sharma adds the ontological refinement that many candidates miss: "The elements are eternal, but their combinations undergo production and dissolution."

⚠ This is a significant doctrinal point. Cārvāka is not a philosophy of universal flux. The material elements are permanent; only configurations arise and perish. That gives Cārvāka a stable ontological substrate — and it is why the school is classified as a realist materialism rather than as a scepticism. It also sharpens the contrast with Buddhism (Subtopic 6) and with Jainism (Subtopic 8).

3. Why ākāśa is rejected — the 2020 question's first half

✓ The argument, in four steps.

1. Earth, water, fire and air are each perceptible: they present themselves through manifest sensible qualities — solidity, fluidity, heat and light, motion and touch.
2. Ākāśa is not perceived as an entity. Chatterjee and Datta: the Cārvākas "reject ether, because its existence cannot be perceived; it has to be inferred." Sharma: "he rejects the fifth, the ether, because it is not perceived but inferred."
3. The inference in question is the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika one: sound (śabda as a quality) is a quality; every quality must inhere in a substance; sound is not a quality of earth, water, fire, air, ātman, manas, time or space; therefore there is a ninth-listed substance, ākāśa, as its unique substrate.
4. Since inference is not a pramāṇa, that argument cannot establish anything. Hence the world is composed of four elements.

⚠ The exchange in table form, which is what a 15-marker needs:

Move	Position
Vaiśeṣika	✓ Sound is heard; qualities require substrates; by elimination the substrate is ākāśa, which is one, eternal, all-pervading and imperceptible
Cārvāka	✓ The hearing of sound is perceptual; the substrate is not. The move from quality to imperceptible substance is an inference and inherits the whole vyāpti problem
Vaiśeṣika rejoinder	⚠ Then sound is left without a bearer, and the doctrine that qualities inhere in substances is broken
Cārvāka reply	⚠ Either sound is a state of the perceptible air-medium, or the demand for a bearer is itself a metaphysical prejudice; positing an imperceptible substrate is an unnecessary multiplication
Assessment	⚠ The Cārvāka is consistent, and the cost is real: he must either naturalise sound into the air or abandon the substance–quality framework that his own four-element realism assumes

⚠ The self-critical point that earns the highest marks on this question. The Cārvāka accepts the four elements as substances. But if he accepts the substance–quality scheme for earth, water, fire and air, he cannot simply refuse it for sound without argument. His most defensible line is therefore not "qualities need no substrates" but "sound is a modification of perceptible air", which is a naturalising move rather than a sceptical one. Saying this shows you have thought past the textbook.

4. Consciousness from matter — bhūta-caitanya-vāda

✓ The transmitted sūtra: kiṇvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam — "consciousness [arises] from matter as the intoxicating power [arises] from fermenting agents."

✓ The problem the doctrine answers. Chatterjee and Datta pose the objection sharply: "we do not perceive consciousness in any of the four material elements. How can it then come to qualify their product, the body?"

✓ The Cārvāka reply — the emergence thesis and its two canonical analogies.

Analogy	The ingredients	The novel property	The point made
Betel (tāmbūla)	Betel leaf, lime and areca nut — "none of which is originally red"	A reddish tinge, "when chewed together"	A property may appear in a combination that is present in no ingredient separately
Fermentation	Molasses (guḍa), "originally non-intoxicant"	Intoxicating power, "when allowed to ferment"	The same substance under a different condition may develop qualities originally absent

✓ Chatterjee and Datta draw the conclusion: "In a similar way, it is possible to think that the material elements combined in a particular way give rise to the conscious living body. Consciousness is an epiphenomenon or by-product of matter; there is no evidence of its existence independent of the body." Sharma reports the same doctrine and quotes the striking Western formulation used of it: "Matter secretes mind as liver secretes bile."

⚠ Read the two analogies carefully, because they are not the same argument.

BETEL : combination of DIFFERENT ingredients -> new quality
(structural / compositional emergence)

FERMENTATION: the SAME ingredient under a NEW CONDITION -> new quality
(processual / transformational emergence)

Together they block two different objections:

- (i) "consciousness is in none of the elements" -> betel answers it
- (ii) "the elements are the same before and after" -> fermentation answers it

△ The explanatory gap, stated honestly — and this is what distinguishes a philosophical answer from a report. Both analogies establish that novel observable qualities can arise from combination. Consciousness, however, is not an observable third-person quality like redness or intoxicating power. It is the condition of observation itself — subjective, first-personal, and, as Sharma notes, private in a way redness is not: consciousness "is neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard", and "consciousness of an individual cannot be shared by others". The analogies therefore establish emergence of the wrong logical type.

△ The Cārvāka's best available reply, which a fair answer must supply: positing an immaterial soul does not close the gap either — it renames it. To say "consciousness arises because there is a conscious substance" explains nothing that "consciousness arises from a specifically organised living body" does not; the dualist has bought a word, not an explanation. △ Assessment: the reply neutralises the dualist's claim to explanatory superiority without discharging the Cārvāka's own explanatory debt. Both sides face the gap; only one side pretends to have crossed it.

5. Why no God is needed — the pot-and-potter exchange and svabhāvavāda

✓ The objection, in Chatterjee and Datta's exact form. "Can the material elements by themselves give rise to this wonderful world? We find that even the production of an object like an earthen jar requires, in addition to clay which is its material cause, a potter who is the efficient cause, that shapes the material into the desired form. The four elements supply only the material cause of the world. Do we not require an efficient cause, like God, as the shaper and designer?"

✓ The Cārvāka reply. "The material elements themselves have got each its fixed nature (svabhāva). It is by the natures and laws inherent in them that they combine together to form this world. There is thus no necessity for God. There is no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design. They can be explained more reasonably as the fortuitous products of the elements."

✓ Chatterjee and Datta then supply the three technical labels, all of which should appear in a 10-marker on Cārvāka metaphysics:

Label	Sanskrit	Meaning	Textbook wording
Naturalism	svabhāvavāda	The world is explained "only by nature"; things behave by their own inherent natures	✓ "Insofar as this Cārvāka theory tries to explain the world only by nature, it is sometimes called naturalism"
Mechanism / accidentalism	yadṛcchāvāda	Denies conscious purpose behind the world; explains it as "a mere mechanical or fortuitous combination of elements"	✓ "It is also called mechanism (yadṛcchā-vāda)"
Positivism	—	Believes "only in positive facts or observable phenomena"	✓ "The Cārvāka theory on the whole may also be called positivism"

△ Note carefully for the 2024 question: the label "positivism" is not an examiner's invention or a modern imposition. It is applied to Cārvāka by the standard textbook itself, and with a stated reason. That is a decisive evidential point for Subtopic 9 and for the workbook's 2024 answer — although, as we shall see, the label still needs heavy qualification.

△ A refinement on svabhāvavāda that strengthens any answer. Svabhāva is invoked twice in Cārvāka, at two different points, and they must not be confused:

- (1) EPISTEMOLOGICAL USE : "why is fire always hot and water cool?"
 -> because of their inherent natures; no supernatural principle is needed, AND "there is neither any guarantee that uniformity perceived in the past would continue in future."
 (Chatterjee & Datta)

- (2) COSMOLOGICAL USE : "who arranged the world?"
 -> nothing did; the elements combine by their own natures; no designer is required.

△ Use (1) is a deflationary appeal: "nature" is a label for observed regularity, deliberately not an explanatory power, and the Cārvāka refuses to guarantee its persistence. Use (2) is a substantive appeal: nature is doing real cosmological work in place of God. The obvious objection — that "nature" is an empty word unless analysed — bites hard on use (2) and hardly at all on use (1). Separating them is the most sophisticated move available in this subtopic.

6. How many materialisms? Sadānanda's fourfold classification

✓ Sharma records, from Sadānanda's Vedāntasāra, that four different materialist schools were distinguished by their identification of the self:

Variant	The self is identified with	Sanskrit
1	The gross body	sthūla śarīra
2	The senses	indriya
3	The vital breaths	prāṇa
4	The mental organ	manas

✓ Sharma adds: "All the schools agree in regarding the soul as a product of matter." He also records Śāntarakṣita's report that the materialist Kambalāśvatara held that consciousness arises out of the material body associated with vital breaths.

△ Exam value. This single table shows that "Cārvāka" names a family of materialist positions, not a monolith. It supports the source-caution of Subtopic 1, it forestalls the objection that the school was crude and undifferentiated, and it gives you a precise, citable internal differentiation almost no other candidate will have.



Advanced refinement

△ Cārvāka materialism is not modern scientific materialism, and saying why is worth marks.

Axis	Cārvāka	Modern scientific materialism
Basic entities	✓ Four perceptible gross elements	Unobservable micro-entities: fields, particles, forces
Attitude to inference	✓ Denies it pramāṇa-status	Depends on it absolutely — theory is inference from data
Attitude to unobservables	✓ Refuses them as unwarranted	Admits them freely when they earn their explanatory keep
Method	△ Polemical minimalism	Experiment, prediction, controlled testing, revision
Status of laws	△ Svabhāva, with no guarantee of future uniformity	Law-like regularities, projectible and quantified

△ The resulting paradox, which is the best single sentence in this subtopic: Cārvāka reaches a materialist conclusion by an anti-inferential route, whereas modern materialism reaches a materialist conclusion by a thoroughly inferential route. The agreement in ontology conceals a total disagreement in method. That sentence is the pivot of any good answer on whether Cārvāka is "scientific" or "positivistic".



Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

△ Bhūta-caitanya-vāda is an early statement of what is now called emergent physicalism, and the objection pressed above — that redness and intoxicating power are third-person properties whereas consciousness is first-personal — is

recognisably the modern explanatory gap objection. ⚠ This is a conceptual parallel offered for one clause of comparative framing. It is not a dated development, it carries no authority, and in a Paper I script it must never displace bhūta, caitanya, svabhāva and the betel and fermentation analogies.

UPSC traps

1. ✓ Four elements, not five. This is the single most examined factual trap in the topic.
2. ✓ Do not say Cārvāka "does not know of" ākāśa. He knows the Vaiśeṣika argument for it and rejects it, precisely because it is inferential.
3. ⚠ Do not say Cārvāka denies the reality of sound. He denies the inference from sound to an imperceptible substrate.
4. ⚠ Do not say the elements are impermanent. Sharma: "the elements are eternal, but their combinations undergo production and dissolution."
5. ⚠ Do not present the betel and fermentation analogies as one analogy. They answer two different objections — compositional and transformational emergence.
6. ⚠ Do not claim the analogies solve the problem of consciousness. State the explanatory gap and the Cārvāka's reply that dualism merely renames it.
7. ⚠ Do not translate svabhāvavāda as "scientific naturalism". It is a metaphysical refusal of teleology, not an experimental programme.
8. ⚠ Do not forget yadṛcchāvāda. The denial of purpose is a distinct thesis from the affirmation of inherent natures, and the two sit together somewhat uneasily.
9. ⚠ Do not treat "Cārvāka" as one uniform doctrine. The Vedāntasāra records four materialist identifications of the self.

Revision notes

- ✓ Bridging principle: ontological commitment must not outrun the accepted pramāṇas. Name it as a presupposition, not a proof.
- ✓ pṛthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni — four elements; and tatsamudāye śarīrendriya-viṣaya-saṃjñā — bodies, senses and objects from their combination.
- ✓ Living bodies too are elemental combinations, "reduced on death" to the elements.
- ✓ The elements are eternal; only their combinations arise and perish (Sharma).
- ✓ Ākāśa is rejected "because it is not perceived but inferred" — the Vaiśeṣika sound-to-substrate inference is refused.
- ✓ kiṇvādiḥyo madaśaktivad vijñānam — consciousness arises as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents.
- ✓ Betel = compositional emergence (leaf, lime, nut → red). Fermentation = transformational emergence (guḍa → intoxicant).
- ✓ Consciousness is an "epiphenomenon or by-product of matter"; "matter secretes mind as liver secretes bile."
- ⚠ Explanatory gap: redness and intoxication are third-person properties; consciousness is private and first-personal. The Cārvāka's best reply is that the soul-hypothesis renames the gap rather than closing it.
- ✓ Pot-and-potter: the objector needs an efficient cause; the Cārvāka answers with svabhāva and denies that design is proved.
- ✓ Three labels from the textbook: naturalism (svabhāvavāda), mechanism (yadṛcchāvāda), and positivism ("believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena").
- ⚠ Separate the deflationary use of svabhāva (regularity, with no guarantee of future uniformity) from the substantive cosmological use (nature in place of God).
- ✓ Vedāntasāra: four materialist schools identify the self with gross body, senses, vital breaths, or manas.
- ⚠ Cārvāka's materialism is anti-inferential; modern materialism is thoroughly inferential. Same conclusion, opposite method.

MCQ 9

Why does the Cārvāka accept earth, water, fire and air while rejecting ākāśa?

- A. Because the first four are perceptible through their manifest sensible qualities, whereas ākāśa is established only by an inference — from sound to an imperceptible substrate — and inference is not admitted as a pramāṇa.
- B. Because ākāśa is accepted only by the Jainas, and Cārvāka's polemic is directed exclusively against Jainism.
- C. Because ākāśa is impermanent while the other four elements are eternal.
- D. Because ākāśa is a quality rather than a substance, and Cārvāka admits only substances.

✓ Correct answer: A. Both textbooks state it in the same terms — Chatterjee and Datta: the Cārvākas "reject ether, because its existence cannot be perceived; it has to be inferred"; Sharma: "he rejects the fifth, the ether, because it is not perceived but inferred." B is historically false: ākāśa is a dravya for Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika, Sāṃkhya, Jainism and Vedānta alike. C inverts the doctrine — ākāśa is classically eternal and all-pervading. D misdescribes the Vaiśeṣika category scheme, in which ākāśa is a substance and sound is its quality.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 10

The betel analogy and the fermentation analogy are both used to defend bhūta-caitanya-vāda. What distinct objection does each answer?

- A. Both answer the same objection, namely that consciousness cannot be perceived.
- B. The betel analogy answers the objection that consciousness is present in none of the four elements taken separately, by showing that a combination may exhibit a property absent from every ingredient; the fermentation analogy answers the objection that the elements are unchanged before and after, by showing that the same material under a different condition may develop a quality originally absent.
- C. The betel analogy establishes that consciousness is red, and the fermentation analogy that it is intoxicating.
- D. The betel analogy is Nyāya's, and the fermentation analogy is Cārvāka's.

✓ Correct answer: B. Chatterjee and Datta give the two cases with exactly this division of labour: betel leaf, lime and nut, "none of which is originally red", acquire a reddish tinge when chewed together; and "even the same thing placed under a different condition may develop qualities originally absent", as molasses becomes intoxicant on fermenting. A collapses two distinct arguments; C is a category confusion; D misattributes both, since the analogies are transmitted as Cārvāka's own — indeed the fermentation case appears in the transmitted Bṛhaspati sūtra kiṇvādhībhya madaśaktivad vijñānam.

✓ Subtopic 5 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now derive the ontology from the epistemology, argue the ākāśa question in both directions, deploy both emergence analogies with their distinct functions, and state svabhāvavāda without over-claiming. Proceeding to the self — the highest-value subtopic in the whole item.

Progress: 6 / 9 | Stage: Advanced | Subtopic: Self, Body and Consciousness — Dehātmavāda, and Cārvāka versus Buddhist Anātmā (2024, 20 marks)

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

📖 Book context: Carvaka.md §2.3, §2.4 and §3.2 (the Cārvāka–Buddhism comparison table) read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §III.2 ("There is no Soul"), including caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā and the first-person judgements, read directly; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §IV, containing the full battery of anti-materialist objections — swoon, dreamless sleep, dream-consciousness, subject–object asymmetry, the two horns of a bull, privacy — read directly; paper-1/indian/Buddhism.md §§3.1–3.5 and §7 on pañcaskandha, santāna, pudgala-nairātmya and the explicit Cārvāka contrast, read directly.

🔍 CA Search: "personal identity, self and the mind–body problem in Indian philosophy — developments February–August 2026"

📖 CA Found: None in last 6 months. No credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. 🔗 The contemporary debate over physicalism and personal identity is used only as an explicitly labelled conceptual link.



VISUAL — Three ways of denying the transcendental self (they are not the same denial)

THE QUESTION: what am I?

NYAYA / VEDANTA (the target)

```

+-----+
|  ATMAN  |
| permanent |
| substance |
| OWNER of |
| states   |
+-----+
  ^
  |
states inhere
in a substance

```

CARVAKA

```

+-----+
|  BODY   |
| qualified |
| by con- |
| sciousness |
+-----+
  ^
  |
"caitanya-
visista deha
eva atma"
  |
SUBSTANCE
RETAINED --
relocated to
the BODY
  |
no rebirth,
no karma
(death = end)

```

BUDDHISM

```

+-----+
| (no owner) |
+-----+
|   |   |   |
| rupa vedana |
| samjna samskara |
| vijñāna |
| (5 skandhas) |
|   |   |   |
| a causal STREAM |
| (santana), no |
| substance, but |
| REAL continuity |
|   |   |   |
| SUBSTANCE |
| ABOLISHED |
|   |   |   |
| rebirth WITHOUT |
| a self; karma |
| preserved |

```

⚠️ Caption. This single diagram is the answer to the 2024 twenty-marker. Cārvāka relocates the self into matter; Buddhism dissolves the self into a process. One keeps a bearer and changes its nature; the other removes the bearer altogether. The moral and soteriological consequences then diverge completely: Cārvāka's denial ends the moral story at death, while Buddhism's denial is designed precisely to keep the moral story running without an owner.

1. Dehātmavāda — the doctrine stated exactly

✓ The transmitted formula: caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ — "the person is the body qualified by consciousness"; and, in Chatterjee and Datta's rendering of the Cārvāka position, "What people mean by a soul is nothing more than this conscious living body (caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā)."

⚠️ Read the formula carefully — every word is load-bearing:

CAITANYA-VISISTA	: QUALIFIED BY CONSCIOUSNESS -> not any body; the LIVING body
KAYAH	: THE BODY -> the perceptible material organism
PURUSAH / ATMA	: IS the person / IS the self -> identity, not correlation

⚠️ Three misreadings to avoid, each of which has sunk otherwise good answers:

1. It is not "the self is the corpse". The self is the living, conscious body; consciousness is the qualifier that makes a body a self.
2. It is not "there is no self". There is a self; it is material. Cārvāka is not an eliminativist about persons.
3. It is not "consciousness is identical with any one element". Consciousness belongs to the organised body-complex, as the emergence analogies establish.

2. The argument for dehātmavāda

✓ Step 1 — the negative argument. "The non-material soul is never perceived" (Chatterjee and Datta). What internal perception delivers is a state, not a substance behind the state.

✓ Step 2 — the positive argument from ordinary first-person judgements. This is the Cārvāka's most distinctive and most quotable move: "we have direct evidence of the identity of the self with the body in our daily experiences and judgments like, 'I am fat,' 'I am lame,' 'I am blind.' If the 'I', the self, were different from the body, these would be meaningless."

△ The logic of the argument from first-person statements, reconstructed:

1. In ordinary speech, bodily predicates are attached directly to "I":
I am fat; I am lame; I am blind; I am hungry; I am tall.
2. Predication of this kind is intelligible only if the SUBJECT and the BEARER of the predicate are the same thing.
3. If "I" named an immaterial soul, "I am fat" would be a CATEGORY MISTAKE -- as odd as "the number seven is blue".
4. But these statements are not category mistakes; they are the ordinary currency of self-description.
5. Therefore "I" refers to the body.

△ The dualist's standard reply, and the Cārvāka's rejoinder. The dualist answers that such expressions are figurative — the soul speaks of its body as a person speaks of "my house". The Cārvāka's rejoinder is that the figurative reading is a theory-driven reinterpretation of language, adopted only to save a doctrine that has no independent perceptual support; and that "my body" and "I am lame" are not on a par, since no one says "my body is lame, therefore I am figuratively lame" in the natural course of speech. △ Assessment: the argument does not prove materialism, but it correctly shifts the burden onto the dualist to explain why ordinary self-ascription runs the way it does.

✓ Step 3 — the argument from covariation. The authored knowledge file records the standard supporting evidence: injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease visibly alter awareness. Consciousness tracks the states of the body with a fidelity that would be inexplicable if it belonged to something else.

✓ Step 4 — the consequence. Chatterjee and Datta: "If the existence of a soul apart from the body is not proved, there is no possibility of proving its immortality. On the contrary, death of the body means the end of the individual. All questions about previous life, after-life, rebirth, enjoyment of the fruits of actions in heaven or hell, therefore, become meaningless."

△ Note the word Chatterjee and Datta use twice: meaningless, not merely false. That is a quasi-verificationist register, and it is a genuine evidential asset for the 2024 "positivism" question — though it must be used carefully, since the Cārvāka has no explicit theory of meaning.

3. The objections — Sharma's full battery, and the Cārvāka's replies

△ This is the richest objection-set in Indian philosophy, and reproducing four or five of these with replies is what turns a 12/20 into an 16/20. Sharma sets them out at length; each is paired below with the best available Cārvāka answer.

#	Objection (Sharma)	Best Cārvāka reply	Residual pressure
1	Self-consciousness. If consciousness means self-consciousness, it cannot be identified with the living body, since animals have living bodies without rational consciousness	△ Only a particular combination of elements, obtaining in the human body, produces consciousness; so no counter-example arises from animals	△ Sharma calls this "wrong": it makes consciousness essential to a specific organisation, which invites objection 2
2	Separability. If consciousness were an essential property of the living body it would be inseparable from it. But "in swoons, fits, epilepsy, dreamless sleep etc. the living body is seen without consciousness"	△ These are states in which the relevant organisation is disrupted; the property is essential to the organisation, not to bare bodily existence	△ Strong reply, but it moves the doctrine from "body" to "functional organisation", which is a real concession
3	Dream-consciousness. "In dreams, consciousness is seen without the living body"; the dreamer on waking disowns the dream-body but owns the dream-consciousness	△ The dreaming subject is the sleeping physical body; the dream-body is imagined content, not a second body	△ The reply is decent; Sharma's inference that consciousness therefore "persists through" waking, dream and deep sleep already presupposes the Vedāntic three-state argument

#	Objection (Sharma)	Best Cārvāka reply	Residual pressure
4	Subject–object asymmetry. "The subject, the knower, cannot be reduced to the object, the known, since all objects presuppose the existence of the subject"; the subject is enjoyer, the object enjoyed	△ A material organism can be both knower and known, as a hand can touch itself; asymmetry of role does not entail difference of substance	△ This is the deepest objection and it is not fully answered; it is the ancestor of the modern subjectivity problem
5	Co-existence is not causation. "The eye cannot see in darkness. Sight is not possible without light, yet light cannot be regarded as the cause of sight"; "the two horns of a bull which are always found together cannot be regarded as causally related." The body may be the instrument of consciousness, not its cause	△ Correct as logic — but the instrument-hypothesis needs an independent user, and no such user is perceived; the materialist hypothesis is the more economical of two unproven options	△ Genuinely undecided; both sides are arguing from the same evidence to different best explanations
6	Imperceptibility of the alleged property. "If consciousness is a property of the body, it must be perceived like other material properties. But it is neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard"	△ It is perceived — by internal perception, which Cārvāka admits	△ But then the Cārvāka's own criterion has been stretched: internal perception delivers something with no external sensory mode, which is precisely the anomaly the dualist is pointing at
7	Privacy. A material property "should be known by all in the same manner and should not be private. But we find that consciousness is intimately private and consciousness of an individual cannot be shared by others"	△ Privacy is explained by the locality of the organism: each body has its own internal states, as each fire has its own heat	△ The reply confuses causal locality with epistemic inaccessibility; the objection retains real force
8	Self-manifestation regress. If consciousness is a property of the body, "why should the body, qualified to produce consciousness, itself stand in need of being manifested by consciousness?"	△ Being a producer of awareness and being an object of awareness are different roles, and one thing may play both	△ A fair reply, though it again concedes a role-distinction that dualists exploit
9	Symmetry of ignorance. "If the existence of the soul surviving death cannot be demonstrated, its non-existence too cannot be so demonstrated"	△ The Cārvāka's principle is asymmetrical by design: the burden lies on the one who posits an entity, not on the one who withholds assent	△ This exposes the difference between not asserting and denying, and most doxographies attribute outright denial rather than agnosticism to Cārvāka

△ The single most useful evaluative sentence to carry from this table: Sharma's objections 2, 3 and 5 show that the Cārvāka's evidence establishes at most a dependence of consciousness on the body, and dependence is compatible with the body being the instrument rather than the cause — so the materialist conclusion is under-determined by the materialist's own evidence. That sentence is worth reproducing in any answer on the Cārvāka self.

4. Memory and personal identity

△ The objection. Memory reaches across time: I remember what I did. What sustains the "I" through the constant replacement of bodily material? A permanent substance seems required.

△ The three answers on the table, and the exam requires you to distinguish them:

School	What secures the identity of the rememberer
Nyāya / Vedānta	✓ A permanent ātman which is the single owner of past experience and present memory
Cārvāka	⚠ Bodily-psychological continuity: the same living organism persists, so the same organism that experienced now recalls. Memory is a bodily-mental trace in a continuing body
Buddhism	✓ Santāna, the causal stream; memory belongs to the same causal continuum, reinforced by pratisandhāna (relinking), and in Yogācāra by ālaya-vijñāna carrying bījas

⚠ The comparative point that examiners reward. Cārvāka and Buddhism both reject the permanent owner, but they replace it with different things: Cārvāka with a material continuant (a body that endures), Buddhism with a causal continuant (a stream in which nothing endures). The Cārvāka answer is metaphysically cheaper and psychologically thinner; the Buddhist answer is metaphysically subtler and must work much harder, which is why it develops santāna, pratisandhāna and eventually ālaya-vijñāna.

5. Solved PYQ — 2024, Q6(a), 20 marks: Cārvāka versus Buddhist rejection of ātmā

✓ Exact question. "Differentiate between the Cārvākas' refutation of self as a transcendental category and the Buddhist rejection of ātmā."

⚠ Demand decoding. The directive is differentiate. The examiner is testing whether the candidate knows that two denials of ātman can be philosophically opposite. The commonest failure is a script that says "both deny the soul" and then describes each separately. That earns the marks of a definition, not of a comparison.

⚠ The comparison matrix — the core of the answer:

Axis	Cārvāka	Buddhism
Formal name of the doctrine	✓ Dehātmavāda — the body is the self	✓ Anātman / nairātmyavāda — no self-substance
What is denied	✓ That the self is a transcendental, immaterial, separable category	✓ That there is any permanent, unchanging, substantial self at all
What is affirmed in its place	✓ A material self: caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ	✓ Five skandhas — rūpa, vedanā, saṃjñā, saṃskāra, vijñāna — with no owner
Underlying ground of the denial	✓ Epistemological: the soul is never perceived, and perception alone is a pramāṇa	✓ Ontological–soteriological: pratītyasamutpāda and kṣaṇikavāda leave no room for a permanent entity; and belief in self generates tṛṣṇā and duḥkha
Status of consciousness	✓ An epiphenomenon, a by-product of the organised body	✓ Vijñāna is one skandha among five — conditioned, momentary, not a product of matter
Is a substance retained?	✓ Yes — substance is relocated into matter	✓ No — substance is abolished; only process remains
Continuity across time	⚠ Bodily-psychological continuity of one organism	✓ Santāna, the causal stream; pratisandhāna; ālaya-vijñāna in Yogācāra
Chariot / analogies	⚠ Betel and fermentation — emergence of a novel quality	✓ The chariot: "chariot" is a name for an arrangement of parts; so is "person"
Rebirth	✓ Rejected — death is the end of the individual	✓ Accepted — rebirth without a transmigrating self
Karma	✓ Rejected as an unseen moral force	✓ Accepted as causal-moral continuity across the stream
Liberation	✓ No mokṣa; "death alone is liberation" (maraṇam eva apavargaḥ)	✓ Nirvāṇa is the central soteriological goal

Axis	Cārvāka	Buddhism
Ethical consequence	⚠ This-worldly prudence; kāma and artha	✓ The eightfold path; compassion; extinction of craving
Internal foil within the tradition	⚠ Sadānanda's four materialist identifications: body, senses, prāṇa, manas	✓ Puggalavāda (Vātsīputrīyas): a pudgala neither identical with nor different from the skandhas — criticised by the mainstream as a relapse into self-theory

⚠ The four differentiating theses to state explicitly — this is the part that converts the table into an answer:

1. DIFFERENT TARGETS. Carvaka denies a TRANSCENDENTAL self and substitutes a MATERIAL one. Buddhism denies a SUBSTANTIAL self of ANY kind, material or immaterial -- so the Buddhist critique applies to Carvaka's body-self as well.
2. DIFFERENT GROUNDS. Carvaka's ground is EPISTEMIC (unperceived). Buddhism's ground is ONTOLOGICAL (dependent origination and momentariness) and SOTERIOLOGICAL (self-belief generates craving).
3. DIFFERENT AFTERMATHS. Carvaka's denial TERMINATES the moral narrative at death. Buddhism's denial is engineered PRECISELY to preserve karma and rebirth without an owner.
4. DIFFERENT METAPHYSICAL PRICES. Carvaka must explain how matter yields subjectivity. Buddhism must explain how a stream without an owner yields memory, responsibility and liberation.

⚠ Model conclusion for the 20-marker. Both schools reject the ātman, but the rejections are not species of a single genus. Cārvāka's is a reductive relocation of the self into perceptible matter, driven by an epistemic restriction and terminating in mortality; Buddhism's is a dissolution of substance into a conditioned process, driven by dependent origination and terminating in nirvāṇa. Indeed the Buddhist analysis refutes Cārvāka as decisively as it refutes Nyāya, since a body-self is still a self. The correct verdict is that Cārvāka denies the transcendence of the self while retaining its substantiality; Buddhism denies its substantiality while retaining its moral continuity.

Advanced refinement

⚠ The point almost no candidate makes, and it is decisive. Buddhism's anātman is not a weaker version of Cārvāka's denial; it is a wider one. Rūpa — material form — is itself one of the five skandhas, and is expressly declared not to be self. The Buddhist analysis therefore rules out the Cārvāka's body-self by name. Writing this sentence demonstrates that you understand the doctrines rather than the labels: for the Buddhist, "I am this body" is one of the very identifications that anātman is formulated to dismantle.

⚠ A second refinement: the Puggalavāda foil. The authored Buddhism file records that some Buddhists, associated with the Vātsīputrīyas, posited a pudgala "neither the same as nor different from the skandhas", and that the mainstream criticised this as a relapse towards self-theory. ⚠ Use this to show that the pressure to preserve a bearer of moral continuity was felt inside Buddhism, and was refused — which makes the contrast with Cārvāka, who simply keeps a bearer and makes it material, doubly instructive.

Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

⚠ The Cārvāka–Buddhist–Nyāya triangle is the Indian version of the contemporary three-cornered debate between substance dualism, reductive physicalism and bundle or process theories of the self. ⚠ Note it in a clause if it helps frame the answer; it is a conceptual parallel only, not a dated development, and the Sanskrit vocabulary must carry the answer.

UPSC traps

1. ✓ Never write that Cārvāka and Buddhism deny the self "in the same way". This is the exact error the 2024 question was designed to catch.
2. ⚠ Do not say Cārvāka denies the self simpliciter. He denies a transcendental self and affirms a material one.
3. ⚠ Do not say Buddhism reduces the person to the body. Rūpa is only one of five skandhas, and is itself denied selfhood.

4. ⚠ Do not say Cārvāka denies consciousness. He denies that consciousness needs an immaterial bearer.
5. ⚠ Do not omit santāna when handling memory in Buddhism; and do not smuggle a soul into it.
6. ⚠ Do not present Sharma's objections as unanswerable. Give the Cārvāka's reply and then assess.
7. ⚠ Do not miss the asymmetry point: Cārvāka's denial ends the moral narrative; Buddhism's denial is constructed to continue it.
8. ⚠ Do not forget the first-person statements — "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind". They are the Cārvāka's own positive argument and are frequently omitted.
9. ⚠ Do not treat "death alone is liberation" as a serious soteriology. It is a rejection of soteriology expressed in soteriological vocabulary.

Revision notes

- ✓ caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ / caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā — the person is the living body qualified by consciousness.
- ✓ Negative argument: "the non-material soul is never perceived."
- ✓ Positive argument: "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind" — bodily predicates attach directly to "I"; on dualism they would be meaningless.
- ✓ Covariation: injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease alter awareness.
- ✓ Consequence: death of the body is the end of the individual; questions of rebirth, heaven and hell "become meaningless".
- ✓ Sharma's objections: swoon and dreamless sleep (body without consciousness) · dreams (consciousness without body) · subject cannot be reduced to object · co-existence is not causation (light and sight; the two horns of a bull) · consciousness is neither smelt, tasted, seen, touched nor heard · consciousness is private · non-existence of the soul is equally undemonstrable.
- ⚠ Best evaluative line: the evidence establishes dependence, and dependence is compatible with the body being the instrument rather than the cause.
- ✓ Memory: Nyāya/Vedānta invoke ātman; Cārvāka invokes bodily-psychological continuity; Buddhism invokes santāna, pratisandhāna and ālaya-vijñāna.
- ✓ 2024 contrast in one line: Cārvāka relocates the self into matter; Buddhism dissolves the self into process.
- ✓ Cārvāka's ground is epistemic; Buddhism's is ontological (pratītyasamutpāda, kṣaṇikavāda) and soteriological (self-belief breeds craving).
- ✓ Cārvāka rejects rebirth, karma and mokṣa; Buddhism retains rebirth, karma and nirvāṇa without a self.
- ⚠ Rūpa is one of the five skandhas — so Buddhist anātman refutes the Cārvāka body-self by name.
- ⚠ Puggalavāda (Vātsīputrīya) is the internal Buddhist foil; Sadānanda's four materialisms are the internal Cārvāka foil.

MCQ 11

Which statement most precisely differentiates the Cārvāka refutation of the self from the Buddhist rejection of ātmā?

- A. Cārvāka denies the self on soteriological grounds, while Buddhism denies it on purely epistemological grounds.
- B. Cārvāka accepts rebirth without a soul, while Buddhism denies rebirth altogether.
- C. Cārvāka denies the transcendence of the self but retains a substantial bearer by identifying the self with the living body, whereas Buddhism denies substantiality as such — including the body-self, since rūpa is itself one of the five skandhas — and replaces the bearer with a causal stream that preserves karma and rebirth.
- D. Both deny the self for identical reasons, differing only in the technical vocabulary they employ.

✓ Correct answer: C. The authored Buddhism file states the point directly: Cārvāka "denies self beyond body and tends toward materialist reduction", while Buddhism "denies permanent self but does not reduce personhood simply to gross body". A reverses the grounds — Cārvāka's is epistemic, Buddhism's ontological and soteriological. B inverts both

positions on rebirth. D is precisely the error the 2024 question was set to detect.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 12

C. D. Sharma objects that "in swoons, fits, epilepsy, dreamless sleep etc. the living body is seen without consciousness", and that "the eye cannot see in darkness; sight is not possible without light, yet light cannot be regarded as the cause of sight." What do these two objections, taken together, establish against the Cārvāka?

- A. That consciousness is a fifth element alongside earth, water, fire and air.
- B. That the Cārvāka's own evidence establishes at most that consciousness depends on the body, and dependence is compatible with the body being the instrument rather than the cause of consciousness — so the materialist conclusion is under-determined by the evidence offered for it.
- C. That consciousness cannot exist at all in a living body.
- D. That perception is not a valid source of knowledge.

✓ Correct answer: B. The first objection attacks the claimed inseparability of consciousness from the living body; the second severs the inference from constant co-occurrence to causation — Sharma adds that "the two horns of a bull which are always found together cannot be regarded as causally related", concluding that "the body is a mere instrument for the manifestation of consciousness and cannot be regarded as its cause." A invents a doctrine no school holds in this form. C is absurd. D would be a Jayarāṣi-style objection, not Sharma's argument here.

✓ Subtopic 6 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You now hold the highest-value comparison in this syllabus item, together with the full objection-and-reply battery. Proceeding to the systematic rejection of transcendent entities.

Progress: 7 / 9 | Stage: Advanced | Subtopic: The Rejection of Transcendent Entities — God, Soul, Karma, Rebirth, Heaven, Mokṣa, Veda and Ritual

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

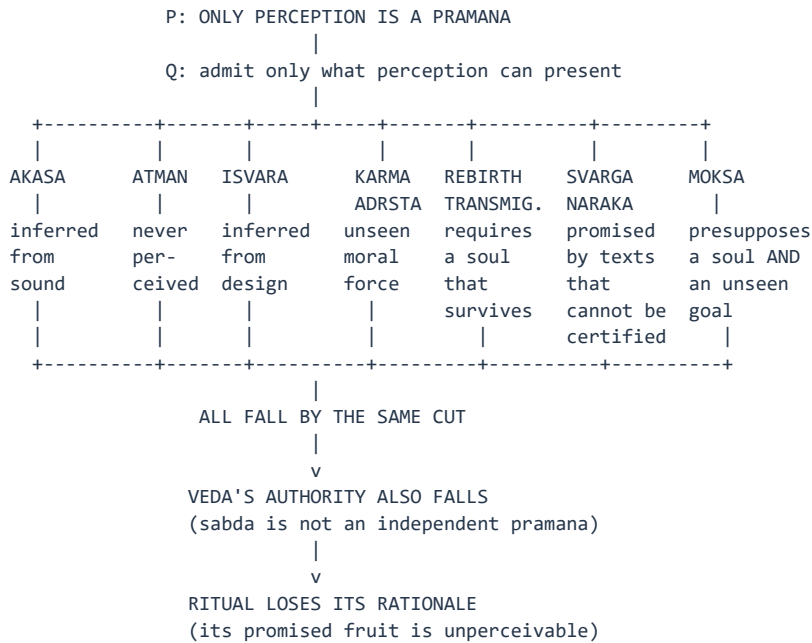
📖 Book context: Carvaka.md §2.1, §2.5, §2.6 and the restored dossier on transmigration read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §III.2–3 and §IV ("Ethics"), including the śrāddha, jyotiṣṭoma and traveller's-food reductions, read directly; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §II ("Sources"), including the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha summary of the Cārvāka position on the Agnihotra, the three Vedas and the "three authors of the Vedas", read directly; _PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md consulted for the exact 2020 Q6(b) and 2021 Q5(e) wording.

🔍 CA Search: "religious scepticism, critiques of ritual authority and transcendental entities — Cārvāka, developments February–August 2026"

📅 CA Found: None in last 6 months. No credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. 🔗 Contemporary scientific scepticism about unfalsifiable claims is noted at the end as a labelled conceptual parallel only, without any evidential or news status.



VISUAL — The demolition tree: one premise, seven casualties



⚠ Caption. This tree is the answer to the 2021 ten-marker in diagram form. The examiner's phrase — "the bearing of Cārvāka epistemology on the rejection of transcendental entities" — asks for exactly this: not a list of denials, but the demonstration that a single epistemic cut severs them all at once.

1. The general form of every Cārvāka denial

⚠ Every denial in this subtopic instantiates one template. Learn the template, not the list.

1. X is claimed to exist.
2. X is not, and cannot in principle be, presented in perception.
3. The only routes to X are inference or scriptural testimony.
4. Neither inference nor testimony is an independent pramāṇa.
5. Therefore there is no valid means by which X could be known.
6. Therefore X should not be admitted into our ontology.

⚠ The precision point at step 6. There is a real difference between withholding assent (agnosticism) and denying (atheism, in the broad sense). ? The doxographical sources overwhelmingly present Cārvāka as denying — "the Cārvākas, therefore, prefer atheism" (Chatterjee and Datta) — but the argument as stated licenses only the weaker conclusion. Sharma records the opposing school's exploitation of exactly this gap: "if the existence of the soul surviving death cannot be demonstrated, its non-existence too cannot be so demonstrated." A first-class answer notes the gap and states which reading it is defending.

2. God — and why svabhāvavāda is the operative reason

✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "God, whose existence cannot be perceived, fares no better than the soul. The material elements produce the world, and the supposition of a creator is unnecessary."

⚠ Two distinct arguments are at work, and separating them is worth marks:

Argument	Form	Force
Epistemic	God is imperceptible; the only routes to God are inference (the design and causal arguments) and śabda; both are denied pramāṇa-status	✓ Removes the warrant for theism
Explanatory (svabhāvavāda)	Even granting the explanatory question, the fixed natures of the elements suffice; "there is no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design"	✓ Removes the need for theism

⚠ Note that the second argument is logically independent of the first, and is the more interesting one, because it engages Nyāya on Nyāya's own ground. Nyāya's kāryāt inference argues from the world as a composite effect to an intelligent efficient cause. The Cārvāka's svabhāvavāda rejoinder does not merely say "you cannot know that"; it says "the explanandum is discharged without you". ⚠ Chatterjee and Datta record the further Cārvāka move: the objects

of the world "can be explained more reasonably as the fortuitous products of the elements" — which is yadṛcchāvāda, and which sits in some tension with a strong svabhāvavāda that grounds regularity in fixed natures. Noting that internal tension is a genuinely advanced observation.

3. Karma, adṛṣṭa and the moral order

✓ Chatterjee and Datta name adṛṣṭa explicitly among the casualties: "God, soul, heaven, life before birth or after death, and any unperceived law (like adṛṣṭa) cannot be believed in, because they are all beyond perception."

⚠ Why adṛṣṭa is the decisive test case. Adṛṣṭa — "the unseen" — is by its own definition imperceptible. It is the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika and Mīmāṃsā device for connecting an act performed now with a fruit enjoyed later, sometimes in another life. The Cārvāka's objection is therefore not incidental but definitional: an entity whose name announces its imperceptibility is precisely what an epistemology of perception must refuse.

✓ The objection from moral order, and the Cārvāka's reply. The authored knowledge file records the exchange: without karma and rebirth, moral order is said to collapse. The Cārvāka answer is that "morality need not be underwritten by cosmic bookkeeping; human pain, pleasure, prudence, and social consequences are enough for practical conduct."

⚠ Assessment to write. The reply establishes that a this-worldly account of moral motivation is available; it does not establish that such an account can support obligations that run against self-interest with no observer. This is the enduring weak point of Cārvāka ethics and connects directly to Subtopic 8.

4. Rebirth and transmigration — the 2020 question's second half

✓ Exact question (2020, Q6(b), 15 marks). "Critically evaluate Cārvākas' rejection of Ākāśa as one of the elements of reality and examine their criticism of transmigration of Soul."

⚠ What transmigration requires, and where Cārvāka cuts each requirement:

Requirement of transmigration	Cārvāka's cut
(a) A self distinct from the body	✓ Dehātmanvāda: the self is the living body; no separable subject exists to migrate
(b) Survival of that self after bodily death	✓ "Death of the body means the end of the individual"; the elements disperse, and the combination that carried consciousness is dissolved
(c) A carrier of moral desert across the gap	✓ Karma and adṛṣṭa are unperceived and hence unwarranted
(d) Knowledge that any of (a)–(c) obtains	✓ Only scripture and inference could supply it; both are denied pramāṇa-status
(e) Meaningfulness of the claim	⚠ Chatterjee and Datta report that questions about "previous life, after-life, rebirth, enjoyment of the fruits of actions in heaven or hell" become meaningless — a quasi-verificationist step

⚠ The critical evaluation the question explicitly demands. A "critically evaluate" question is not answered by exposition. Supply both sides:

STRENGTHS of the Carvaka position

- (i) consistency: the same criterion cuts akāśa, ātman and rebirth alike
- (ii) economy: nothing unobservable is posited
- (iii) anti-exploitation: it removes the machinery on which ritual prescription and priestly authority rested
- (iv) it forces every rival school to say HOW an unseen bearer of desert is known -- a demand Nyaya answers only inferentially

WEAKNESSES

- (i) the argument rests on the rejection of inference, which is itself vulnerable (Subtopics 3-4)
- (ii) dependence of consciousness on the body does not entail production by the body (Sharma's instrument objection)
- (iii) "not established" is slid into "does not exist"
- (iv) the disappearance of moral continuity leaves desert and obligation without any ground beyond prudence
- (v) Sharma: the non-existence of a surviving soul is as undemonstrable as its existence

⚠ Verdict formula for this question: The rejection of ākāśa and of transmigration are the same argument applied twice — once to cosmology and once to soteriology — and their force is exactly the force of the underlying epistemology. Where that epistemology is defensible, as a demand that metaphysical postulates earn their keep, the rejection is powerful; where it over-reaches, in converting "unestablished" into "unreal", the rejection outruns its warrant.

5. Heaven, hell and mokṣa

✓ Heaven. Chatterjee and Datta: the Mīmāṃsakas hold that the highest goal is heaven (svarga), "a state of unalloyed bliss that can be attained hereafter by performing here the Vedic rites. The Cārvāka rejects this view, because it is based on the unproved existence of a life after death. 'Heaven' and 'hell' are the inventions of the priests whose professional interest lies in coaxing, threatening and making people perform the rituals. Enlightened men will always refuse to be duped by them."

✓ Liberation. The Cārvāka argument is a dilemma, and it is elegant:

What could "liberation" mean?

HORN 1: freedom of the SOUL from bondage to physical existence
-> "absurd, because there is no soul"

HORN 2: attainment, IN THIS LIFE, of a state free from ALL pain
-> "an impossible ideal. Existence in this body is bound up with pleasure as well as pain."

RESIDUE: "Liberation in the sense of complete cessation of sufferings can only mean DEATH." -> maranam eva apavargah

✓ Both horns and the residue are given verbatim in substance by Chatterjee and Datta, and the residue is one of the six transmitted Bṛhaspati sūtras.

⚠ How to present maraṇam eva apavargah without caricature. It is not a recommendation of death and it is not nihilism. It is a reductio of the concept of liberation: if mokṣa means the total cessation of suffering, then the only state that satisfies the definition is the one no wise person would work for. The verse is a critique of the coherence of the goal, not an endorsement of dying. Saying this in one sentence is worth a mark and protects you from the commonest misreading in the topic.

6. The Veda, priesthood and the ritual reductions

✓ The epistemic charge. Śabda is not an independent pramāṇa (Subtopic 2); Vedic authority therefore has no certified standing. Claims of authorlessness or infallibility are not perceptually available.

✓ The sociological charge. Chatterjee and Datta report it plainly: "in reality the Vedas are the works of some cunning priests who earned their living by duping the ignorant and the credulous", and the tangible benefit of the rites goes to "the priests who officiate and enjoy the emoluments."

✓ The Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha summary, as reproduced by Sharma, is the sharpest form of the polemic and should be used with an explicit source-caution: "There is no heaven, no final liberation, nor any soul in another world; nor do the actions of the four castes, orders etc. produce any real effect. The Agnihotra, the three Vedas, the ascetic's three staves and smearing one's self with ashes, were made by Nature as the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness... (All the ceremonies are) a means of livelihood (for) Brāhmaṇas. The three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons."

✓ The three ritual reductions — each is a genuine argument, not merely abuse, and each has the same logical shape: take the ritual's own premise seriously, and derive an absurdity the practitioner will not accept.

#	The reductio	The premise it tests	The absurdity generated
1	The śrāddha argument. If the food offered at the funeral ceremony can appease the hunger of the departed, "what is the use of a traveller's taking food with him? Why should not his people make some offerings in his name at home to satisfy his hunger?"	That an offering here nourishes a person elsewhere	⚠ Nourishment at a distance would make travel provisions pointless — a consequence no one accepts

#	The reductio	The premise it tests	The absurdity generated
2	The upstairs argument. "Food offered on the ground floor should satisfy a person living upstairs."	The same, in miniature	⚠ A vivid reductio of action-at-a-distance nourishment
3	The jyotiṣṭoma argument. "If the priests really believe, as they say, that the animals killed at a sacrifice are sure to reach heaven, why do they not rather sacrifice their own old parents instead of animals and make heaven sure for them?"	That ritual slaughter secures heaven for the victim	⚠ The priest's refusal reveals that he does not believe his own premise — an argument from revealed preference

⚠ The philosophically important observation to add. The jyotiṣṭoma argument is not a joke; it is an early and powerful use of revealed preference as evidence about belief. It says: your unwillingness to apply your doctrine where it would cost you shows that you do not hold it in the way you profess. That is a serious epistemic argument and deserves to be presented as one.

⚠ The balance an answer must strike. Chatterjee and Datta themselves describe the Cārvākas as raising "cheap laughter at the customary rites". An answer that reproduces only the abuse looks unserious; an answer that reproduces only the epistemology misses the school's historical bite. Present the polemic and extract the argument inside it.

7. Solved PYQ — 2021, Q5(e), 10 marks

✓ Exact question. "Comment on the bearing of Cārvāka epistemology on the rejection of transcendental entities by them."

⚠ Demand decoding. The key word is bearing — the examiner wants the derivation, not two separate lists. A script that describes the epistemology in one paragraph and the denials in another has not answered the question, however accurate each paragraph is.

⚠ Model answer (≈160 words).

For Cārvāka, ontology is the shadow cast by epistemology. Perception alone is a pramāṇa: anumāna fails because vyāpti can be established neither by perception (all cases are never surveyed), nor by inference (petitio principii), nor by testimony (whose own validity is inferred); and śabda fails because words certify only that something was said. Chatterjee and Datta accordingly state that the Cārvāka theory of reality "follows from" this epistemological conclusion.

The bearing is immediate and systematic. Ākāśa falls because it is inferred from sound, not perceived. Ātman falls because no soul is ever perceived apart from the living body. Īśvara falls because he is reached only by design-inference, and svabhāva discharges the explanatory work. Karma, adṛṣṭa, rebirth, svarga and mokṣa fall because each is either an unseen force or a post-mortem state that no perception could present. Vedic authority falls with śabda, and ritual loses its rationale with it.

⚠ Verdict to append if space allows: the derivation is impeccably consistent; its cost is that the epistemic premise is itself vulnerable, so the entire ontology stands or falls with the rejection of inference.



Advanced refinement

⚠ Cārvāka's atheism is structurally different from every other Indian denial of God, and this comparison is high-value in Paper I and Paper II alike.

School	Denies a creator God because	Accepts anumāna?	Accepts scriptural authority?
Cārvāka	✓ No pramāṇa establishes him, and svabhāva suffices	✗ No	✗ No
Sāṃkhya	✓ Prakṛti explains evolution; a God is superfluous and would compromise puruṣa's inactivity	✓ Yes	✓ Yes

School	Denies a creator God because	Accepts anumāna?	Accepts scriptural authority?
Mīmāṃsā	✓ The Veda is apauruṣeya and apūrva matures without a dispenser	✓ Yes	✓ Yes — supremely
Jainism	✓ The world is uncreated; karma is material and self-operating; but godhood is attained by the liberated soul	✓ Yes	✗ Rejects Vedic authority
Buddhism	✓ Dependent origination explains arising; an immutable cause cannot yield succession	✓ Yes	✗ Rejects Vedic authority

△ The resulting single sentence, which is worth memorising: Cārvāka is the only Indian school whose atheism is generated by its epistemology rather than by its cosmology or its soteriology — which is why it also rejects the karma, rebirth and liberation that Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism all retain. Non-theism is common in Indian philosophy; this-worldliness is Cārvāka's alone.

🔗 Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

🔗 The demand that a postulate be in principle checkable, and the treatment of unfalsifiable claims as unwarranted rather than merely unproved, is conceptually parallel to modern scientific scepticism and to verificationist criteria of meaning. △ Offer this as a labelled conceptual parallel only, and be careful: the parallel is exactly what makes the 2024 "positivism" question tempting and what makes an unqualified "yes" to it wrong, since Cārvāka rejects the very inferential machinery on which modern science runs.

UPSC traps

- △ Do not present the denials as a list. Show the derivation from the single epistemic premise — that is what "bearing" means in 2021 Q5(e).
- △ Do not slide from "not established" to "does not exist" without noticing. Sharma exploits exactly that slide.
- △ Do not read maraṇam eva apavargaḥ as a recommendation of death. It is a reductio of the concept of liberation.
- △ Do not reduce the ritual criticisms to abuse. The śrāddha and jyotiṣṭoma arguments are genuine reductios, and the second is an argument from revealed preference.
- △ Do not quote the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha invective without a source-caution; it is a summary preserved by an opponent.
- △ Do not say "Cārvāka is the only atheist school in India". Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism are all non-theistic. Cārvāka is the only school whose atheism follows from its epistemology and which also discards karma, rebirth and liberation.
- △ Do not forget adṛṣṭa by name. It is the perfect test case, since its name means "the unseen".
- △ Do not miss the internal tension between svabhāvavāda (fixed natures grounding regularity) and yadṛcchāvāda (fortuitous combination). Noting it is a mark of independent thought.

Revision notes

- ✓ The template: X is imperceptible → only inference or testimony could reach X → neither is a pramāṇa → X is unwarranted → X is rejected.
- △ Note the gap between withholding assent and denying; the doxographies attribute denial, the argument licenses only the weaker conclusion.
- ✓ God falls twice over: epistemically (no pramāṇa) and explanatorily (svabhāva suffices; "no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design").
- ✓ Adṛṣṭa is named explicitly among the casualties — "any unperceived law (like adṛṣṭa)".
- ✓ Transmigration requires a separable self, its survival, a carrier of desert, and knowledge of all three; Cārvāka cuts every one.

- ✓ Heaven and hell are "the inventions of the priests"; svarga is rejected because it rests on "the unproved existence of a life after death".
- ✓ The liberation dilemma: freedom of a soul (absurd — there is no soul) or freedom from all pain in this life (impossible — embodiment mixes pleasure and pain); residue — maraṇam eva apavargaḥ.
- ✓ Three ritual reductios: śrāddha and the traveller's food · food downstairs for a person upstairs · jyotiṣṭoma and "why not sacrifice their own old parents".
- ✓ Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha: Agnihotra, the three Vedas, the three staves and ashes are "the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness"; "the three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons" — quote with a source-caution.
- ⚠ The jyotiṣṭoma argument is an argument from revealed preference about what the priest actually believes.
- ⚠ Cārvāka is not the only non-theistic Indian school; it is the only one whose atheism is generated epistemologically, and the only one that also discards karma, rebirth and mokṣa.
- ⚠ Internal tension worth noting: svabhāvavāda grounds regularity in fixed natures, while yadr̥cchāvāda calls the world's objects "fortuitous products".

MCQ 13

What is the precise sense of the transmitted Cārvāka sūtra maraṇam eva apavargaḥ, "death alone is liberation"?

- A. It is a reductio of the concept of mokṣa: if liberation means freedom of a soul there is no soul to free, and if it means a state free from all pain then embodiment cannot supply it — so the only state satisfying the definition is death, which no wise person would pursue.
- B. It is a positive soteriology recommending suicide as the highest human goal.
- C. It asserts that the soul attains liberation at the moment of death, as in Jainism.
- D. It means that liberation is attained by ritual performance at the time of death.

✓ Correct answer: A. Chatterjee and Datta set out the dilemma exactly: if liberation is freedom of the soul from bondage to physical existence "it is absurd because there is no soul", and if it is a pain-free state in this very life "it is also an impossible ideal", since "existence in this body is bound up with pleasure as well as pain" — hence "liberation in the sense of complete cessation of sufferings can only mean death". They add that "no wise man would willingly work for that end". B is the caricature the reductio is designed to expose. C attributes a soul the school denies. D restores the ritual efficacy the school rejects.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 14

Which statement best identifies what is distinctive about Cārvāka's rejection of God among the Indian schools?

- A. Cārvāka is the only Indian school that does not accept a creator God.
- B. Cārvāka's rejection is generated by its epistemology — no pramāṇa establishes God, and svabhāva discharges the explanatory work — whereas Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism reject a creator on cosmological, exegetical or soteriological grounds while retaining inference, karma, rebirth and liberation.
- C. Cārvāka rejects God but retains adr̥ṣṭa as the impersonal moral law.
- D. Cārvāka rejects God because the Veda, correctly interpreted, is atheistic.

✓ Correct answer: B. Non-theism is widespread in Indian philosophy — Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism all deny a creator — which makes A false. What is unique to Cārvāka is the epistemological route and the accompanying rejection of karma, rebirth and mokṣa, which the other non-theistic schools retain. C is false: Chatterjee and Datta name "any unperceived law (like adr̥ṣṭa)" among the entities rejected. D is false: Cārvāka rejects Vedic authority outright rather than reinterpreting it.

✓ Subtopic 7 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now derive every denial from the single epistemic premise, evaluate the transmigration critique on both sides, and present the ritual polemic as argument rather than

abuse. Proceeding to ethics and the social meaning of the school.

Progress: 8 / 9 | Stage: Advanced | Subtopic: Ethics and the Political-Social Meaning — and Cārvāka versus Jaina Reality (2020, 15 marks)

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

 Book context: Carvaka.md §2.7, §2.9 and §4.3 read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §IV ("Ethics") and §V ("Conclusion") — including the dhūrta / suśikṣita distinction, Vātsyāyana's refined hedonism, the sixty-four fine arts, the king-as-God report and the incorporation of daṇḍanīti and vārttā — read directly; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §V ("Ethics") and §IV, including the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha "debt and ghee" verse and the anekāntavāda material in Chapter Four, read directly; paper-1/indian/Jainism.md §§1.1–1.7 and §4.3 read directly for the 2020 comparison.

 CA Search: "hedonism, secular ethics and this-worldly value theory in Indian philosophy — Cārvāka, developments February–August 2026"

 CA Found: None in last 6 months. No credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026.  Contemporary secular and naturalistic ethics are noted at the end only as a labelled conceptual parallel.

VISUAL — The puruṣārtha ledger, and the two axes of the Cārvāka position

THE FOUR PURUSARTHAS		CARVAKA'S VERDICT	
-----		-----	
DHARMA	(virtue / duty)	----->	REJECTED : "distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted"
ARTHA	(wealth)	----->	ACCEPTED as MEANS, not as end
KAMA	(enjoyment)	----->	ACCEPTED as THE END
MOKSA	(liberation)	----->	REJECTED : obtainable "only by death, and no wise man would work for that"

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+-----+
| ARTHA ---- means ----> KAMA |
|                               |
|                               |
+-----+

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AND WITHIN "KAMA" THERE ARE TWO CARVAKAS:

DHURTA (cunning/crude)	SUSIKSITA (cultured/refined)
-----	-----
gross sensual pleasure	pleasure disciplined by the
immediate gratification	sixty-four fine arts, self-
egoistic hedonism	control and urbanity
the caricature the	Vatsyayana's Kama-sutra as the
opponents preserved	"best positive evidence"
	(Chatterjee & Datta)

 Caption. Two axes, not one. The first axis is which puruṣārthas survive; the second is what kind of hedonist is doing the surviving. Almost every weak answer collapses the second axis and presents only the dhūrta. The textbooks themselves refuse that collapse.

1. The doctrine, stated exactly

✓ The transmitted sūtra: kāma evaiḥ puruṣārthaḥ — "enjoyment is the only end of human life."

✓ The four-fold verdict, in Chatterjee and Datta's exact terms: "Of these four, the Cārvāka rejects the last two. Liberation in the sense of destruction of all sufferings can be obtained only by death and no wise man would willingly work for that end. Virtue and vice are distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted. Therefore neither liberation nor virtue should be our end. Wealth and enjoyment are the only rational ends that a wise man can toil to achieve. But enjoyment is the ultimate end; wealth is not an end in itself, it is good only as a means to enjoyment."

△ Two things to notice, both examinable.

1. The rejection of dharma is epistemically driven, not merely appetitive. Dharma is rejected because it is a scriptural category and śabda is not a pramāṇa — the same cut that removed ākāśa and ātman. Writing "Cārvāka rejects virtue because he loves pleasure" reverses the direction of the argument.
2. Artha is subordinated, not co-ordinate. Cārvāka is not a materialist about wealth; wealth is instrumental. That is a real ethical thesis and it separates Cārvāka from mere acquisitiveness.

2. The standard of right action, and its consequentialist form

✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "A good action is one which leads to a balance of pleasure and a bad action is one which brings about more pain than pleasure. This Cārvāka ethics may be called, therefore, hedonism or the theory that pleasure is the highest goal."

△ The structure of the criterion, made explicit:

VALUE THEORY	: pleasure is the sole intrinsic good; pain the sole intrinsic evil
NORMATIVE THEORY	: the right action is the one whose balance of pleasure over pain is greatest
SCOPE	: the doxographies present the scope as EGOISTIC -- "pleasure of the senses in this life and that too of the individual is the sole end" (Sharma)
BUT	: Chatterjee & Datta explicitly deny that ALL materialists were egoistic hedonists

△ The scope question is where the real philosophy is. Egoistic hedonism and universalistic hedonism share a value theory and differ entirely in their normative consequences. Chatterjee and Datta record the decisive consideration: "Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is not compatible with social discipline. Life in society is impossible if man does not sacrifice a part of his pleasures for others." And they immediately supply the evidence that some Cārvākas saw this: "Some Cārvākas, we are told, regard the king as God. This implies their great faith in the necessity of society and its head."

3. Refined hedonism — the evidence, and why it matters

✓ The dhūrta / suśikṣita distinction. Chatterjee and Datta: "a distinction found sometimes between the cunning (dhūrta) and cultured (suśikṣita) Cārvākas makes it likely that the Cārvākas were not all of the same gross, uncultured type." Sharma records the same twofold division of "Crude and Refined Materialists".

✓ The evidence for refinement, as Chatterjee and Datta present it:

Evidence	Detail
The fine arts	Materialists "devoted themselves also to the pursuit of more refined pleasures by cultivating, for example, the fine arts, the number of which is as large as sixty-four (catuḥ-ṣaṣṭi-kalāḥ), according to Vātsyāyana"
Political philosophy and economics	"Political philosophy and economy (daṇḍanīti and vārttā) came to be incorporated at some stage in the philosophy of the Lokāyatikas"
The king as God	Reported of some Cārvākas — implying "great faith in the necessity of society and its head"
Vātsyāyana's Kāma-sūtra	"The best positive evidence of refined hedonism is found in the ethical philosophy propounded by Vātsyāyana in the second chapter of the Kāma-sūtra"

✓ Vātsyāyana's position, stated precisely — and note the important qualification. Chatterjee and Datta are careful: "Though Vātsyāyana believes in God and in life after death and, therefore, is not a materialist in the ordinary sense, yet he may be regarded as one, according to a wider sense of the term, namely, one who tries to explain 'higher phenomena by lower ones'." His materialist tendency "consists in holding that dharma and artha are to be treated only as means to enjoyment, which is therefore the supreme end."

✓ The content of the refinement, which is the material that rescues Cārvāka ethics from caricature:

1. Emphasis on self-control (brahmacarya), spiritual discipline (dharma) and urbanity (nāgarika-vṛtti), "without which human enjoyment of pleasure is reduced to the level of beastly enjoyment."
2. All kāma is "ultimately reducible to the gratification of the five senses"; the satisfaction of the senses is "necessary for the very existence of the body (śarīra-sthiti)", like the satisfaction of hunger.
3. The senses "must be educated, disciplined and cultured through a training in the sixty-four fine arts", given only after "absolute self-continenence and study" in the earlier part of life.
4. Against the impatient hedonist who will not "forgo present comfort" or "undergo any toil for future enjoyment", Vātsyāyana argues that such an attitude "would be suicidal", since it "would prevent a man even from the toil of cultivation and sowing seeds in the hope of the future enjoyment of a crop."
5. "Inordinate desire, inconsistent with the principles of dharma and wealth, leads to ruin and annihilates the chances of all enjoyment."
6. He argues, "like a modern scientific man, that some science is at the root of every successful practice."

△ The philosophical upshot, and it is important. Point 4 is a prudential argument internal to hedonism: unregulated present gratification is self-defeating on hedonistic grounds. That is exactly the structure of Epicurus' argument in the West, and it means that the refined Cārvāka position is not a compromise with morality imported from outside — it is what consistent hedonism requires of itself. Chatterjee and Datta conclude that Vātsyāyana "represents Indian hedonism at its best", and that the name suśikṣita-cārvāka was "perhaps" applied to thinkers of this kind.

△ The honest counterweight. Sharma's verdict is far harsher and must be carried too: "The ethics of the Cārvāka is a crude individual hedonism"; "All values are mere phantoms created by a diseased mind"; and he locates the school's downfall not in its atheism or its materialism — which it shares with respected schools — but in "the Cārvāka's denial of all human values which make life worth living... Sensual pleasure is a very faint shadow of the supreme pleasure. There is a qualitative difference in pleasure. The pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher."

△ How to adjudicate in an answer. The two verdicts are about different things and both are usable:

SHARMA'S TARGET	: the doctrine as transmitted in the doxographies -- gross, egoistic, quantitative hedonism
CHATTERJEE & DATTA'S TARGET	: the historical breadth of the movement -- the susikṣita strand, the fine arts, dandaniti and varta, the king-as-God report, Vatsyayana's discipline
VERDICT TO WRITE	: the transmitted doctrine is vulnerable to Sharma's "pleasure of the pig" objection because it offers no QUALITATIVE distinction among pleasures; the refined strand supplies a PRUDENTIAL and CULTURAL regulation of pleasure but still no independent standard of value. Carvaka can be made prudent; it cannot easily be made moral.

4. The "debt and ghee" verse — and the source caution

? The verse, as preserved in the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha and reproduced by Sharma: "While life remains let a man live happily, let him feed on ghee (clarified butter) even though he runs in debt; when once the body becomes ashes, how can it ever return here?"

△ The source caution, which must accompany every use of this verse. This is:

1. A verse preserved in a fourteenth-century doxography compiled by Mādhava, a Vedāntin — that is, by an opponent;
2. Presented in a chapter whose purpose is refutation;
3. Not attributable to any surviving primary Cārvāka text;
4. Frequently paraphrased in exam scripts as yāvaj jīvet sukhaṃ jīvet, which the authored knowledge file itself flags as a doxographical verse associated with the tradition, not a securely locatable quotation from an extant primary Cārvāka text.

△ How to use it correctly in an answer: "The often-quoted verse — live happily, feed on ghee even in debt, for the body once turned to ashes does not return — is preserved in the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha, an opponent's compendium, and should be treated as a doxographical characterisation of the school's spirit rather than as its own scripture." That single sentence signals scholarly care and forestalls the examiner's objection.

△ The philosophical point beneath the rhetoric. Strip away the polemic and the verse encodes a real argument: if there is no post-mortem accounting, then the discounting of present goods in favour of future or other-worldly ones is irrational. That is an argument about the rationality of deferral under a finite horizon, and it is answerable — Vātsyāyana himself answers it, in point 4 above, by observing that a refusal to defer would prevent even sowing a crop. Presenting the verse with its internal rebuttal is far better than quoting it as a slogan.

5. Positivistic, naturalistic, secular — a first pass at the 2024 label

△ Full treatment belongs to Subtopic 9 and the workbook, but the ethical material contributes three of the strongest points:

Label	Why it fits ✓	Why it must be qualified △
Naturalistic	Svabhāvavāda; value grounded in embodied pleasure and pain; no supernatural sanction	The notion of "nature" is descriptive, not analysed into laws
Secular	Morality is detached from scripture and priesthood; daṇḍanīti and vārtā enter the school; the king, not God, is the guarantor of order	The detachment is polemical rather than institutional; no political theory survives
Positivistic	✓ Chatterjee and Datta apply the word themselves: the theory "may also be called positivism, because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena"; they add that the Cārvāka view "that no inference can yield certain knowledge is the view of many contemporary Western thinkers like the pragmatists and logical positivists"	△ Positivism venerates science, which is built on inference; Cārvāka attacks inference. Positivism has a constructive programme; Cārvāka has a polemical minimalism. And Comte's positivism carries a philosophy of history and a sociology entirely absent here

6. Solved PYQ — 2020, Q7(c), 15 marks: Cārvāka versus Jaina conceptions of reality

✓ Exact question. "Explain the differences of conception of Reality between Cārvāka and Jainism."

△ Demand decoding. The axis is conception of reality — metaphysics and the epistemology that licenses it — not ethics, and not "materialism versus spirituality" as a slogan. The best answers run four or five explicit axes.

△ The comparison matrix:

Axis	Cārvāka	Jainism
Number of pramāṇas	✓ One — pratyakṣa alone	✓ Several; knowledge is fivefold — mati, śruta, avadhi, manaḥparyāya, kevala
Basic definition of the real	△ Whatever is perceptible; matter in combination	✓ Sat = utpāda-vyaya-dhauvya — origination, decay and persistence together
Ultimate constituents	✓ Four bhūtas: earth, water, fire, air	✓ Six dravyas: jīva, pudgala, dharma, adharma, ākāśa, kālā
Ākāśa	✓ Rejected — inferred, not perceived	✓ Accepted as a distinct dravya providing accommodation
Souls	✓ None; the self is the living body	✓ Infinitely many jīvas, each intrinsically conscious; consciousness is the soul's inseparable essence, not (as the Cārvākas hold) "a mere accidental property, arising only under some conditions"
Substance and mode	△ Elements eternal, combinations transient; no developed guṇa-paryāya analysis	✓ Every dravya has guṇa (essential qualities) and paryāya (modes); the gold-ornament example

Axis	Cārvāka	Jainism
Truth and standpoint	⚠ Single standpoint; no level-distinction at all	✓ Anekāntavāda — reality is many-faced; nayavāda and syādvāda; the seven-fold predication
Attitude to universals	⚠ Denied — Sharma notes the Jaina charge that materialism views "particulars alone as real and universals as unreal"	✓ Real, though standpoint-conditioned
Karma	✓ Rejected as an unseen force	✓ Accepted, and uniquely as subtle material substance adhering to the jīva; bhāvabandha and dravyabandha
Liberation	✓ None; maraṇam eva apavargaḥ	✓ Mokṣa through the three jewels and the five mahāvratas; kevala-jñāna
Overall type	⚠ Materialist monism of substance, pluralist only about elemental kinds	✓ Realistic and relativistic pluralism — "common-sense realism and pluralism"
Shared ground	✓ Both are nāstika — both reject Vedic authority; both are realists about the perceptible world; both reject a creator God	

⚠ The two sentences that lift this answer above a list.

1. The deepest difference is not materialism versus spiritualism but the number of standpoints each allows: Jainism's anekāntavāda multiplies both entities and points of view, while Cārvāka admits a single standpoint and the barest possible furniture — and this is why Jainism can accommodate change and persistence together while Cārvāka must simply assert that the elements are eternal and their combinations are not.
2. Their agreement is as instructive as their disagreement: both are nāstika, both are realists about the perceptible world, and both refuse a creator God — so the classification "nāstika" tells you almost nothing about a school's metaphysics.

Advanced refinement

⚠ Was Cārvāka a social philosophy? Two pieces of evidence, both from Chatterjee and Datta, suggest more than pure appetite: the incorporation of daṇḍanīti (political philosophy, the science of governance) and vārttā (economics, the science of livelihood) into the philosophy of the Lokāyatikas; and the report that some Cārvākas "regard the king as God". ⚠ The natural reading is a secular theory of political authority: order is guaranteed not by cosmic dharma or divine sanction but by the sovereign, and prosperity by the productive arts. ? The evidence is thin and doxographical, and must be presented as suggestive rather than established — but it is precisely the material that saves a Cārvāka answer from ending in caricature, and it directly supports the "secular" half of the 2024 label.

⚠ A final ethical refinement. Cārvāka's ethics lacks two things that every rival supplies: a qualitative distinction among pleasures (Sharma's "pleasure of the pig") and an account of other-regarding obligation. Vātsyāyana supplies a partial answer to the first through cultivation and the fine arts, and Chatterjee and Datta gesture at the second through the necessity of social discipline and the king. But neither is derived from the Cārvāka's own value theory; both are added to it. ⚠ The honest verdict: Cārvāka's ethics is a fully coherent theory of prudence and an incomplete theory of morality.

Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

🔗 Cārvāka's grounding of value in embodied pleasure and pain, without supernatural sanction, is conceptually parallel to modern secular and naturalistic ethics; and the dhūrta / suśikṣita distinction mirrors the Western contrast between crude and refined, or quantitative and qualitative, hedonism. ⚠ Conceptual parallel only, offered in a clause; not a dated development, and never a substitute for puruṣārtha, kāma, artha and the Sanskrit sources.

UPSC traps

1. ⚠ Do not reduce Cārvāka ethics to reckless sensualism. The textbooks themselves distinguish dhūrta from suśikṣita Cārvākas.

2. △ Do not say Cārvāka rejects dharma because he prefers pleasure. He rejects it because it is a scriptural category, and śabda is not a pramāṇa.
3. △ Do not treat artha as a second end. It is explicitly a means to kāma.
4. ? Do not quote the "ghee and debt" verse as Cārvāka scripture. It is preserved in the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha, an opponent's compendium.
5. △ Do not call Vātsyāyana a Cārvāka without qualification. He "believes in God and in life after death" and is a materialist only "according to a wider sense of the term".
6. △ Do not omit daṇḍanīti, vārttā and the king-as-God report if the question touches the school's social or political meaning.
7. △ Do not answer the 2020 Jainism comparison with "materialism versus spirituality". Run the axes: pramāṇas, definition of the real, constituents, ākāśa, soul, substance–mode, standpoint, karma, liberation.
8. △ Do not forget that Jainism holds consciousness to be the soul's inseparable essence, expressly denying the Cārvāka view that it is "a mere accidental property, arising only under some conditions".
9. △ Do not present Sharma's harsh verdict and Chatterjee and Datta's sympathetic one as a contradiction. They target different objects — the transmitted doctrine and the historical movement.

Revision notes

- ✓ kāma evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ — enjoyment is the only end; artha is its means; dharma and mokṣa are rejected.
- ✓ Dharma is rejected on epistemic grounds: virtue and vice are "distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted".
- ✓ Criterion of right action: a good action yields a balance of pleasure; a bad one brings more pain than pleasure. Hence hedonism.
- ✓ Dhūrta (cunning/crude) versus suśikṣita (cultured/refined) Cārvākas — the textbooks refuse a single, gross portrait.
- ✓ Evidence for refinement: the sixty-four fine arts (catuḥ-ṣaṣṭi-kalāḥ); daṇḍanīti and vārttā incorporated into Lokāyata; some Cārvākas regard the king as God.
- ✓ Vātsyāyana is "the best positive evidence of refined hedonism" — but he believes in God and an afterlife and so is a materialist only "in a wider sense".
- ✓ Vātsyāyana's regulation: brahmacharya, urbanity (nāgarika-vṛtti), education of the senses, and the argument that refusing to defer would prevent even sowing a crop.
- ✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is not compatible with social discipline."
- △ Sharma's counterweight: "crude individual hedonism"; the school fell through "the denial of all human values"; "the pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher."
- ? The "ghee and debt" verse comes from the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha — an opponent's compendium; quote with caution, and extract the argument about deferral under a finite horizon.
- ✓ Chatterjee and Datta apply the word positivism to Cārvāka themselves — "because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena" — and compare its view of inference to the pragmatists and logical positivists.
- ✓ 2020 comparison: one pramāṇa versus five kinds of knowledge · four bhūtas versus six dravyas · ākāśa rejected versus accepted · no soul versus infinite jīvas with consciousness as inseparable essence · single standpoint versus anekāntavāda and syādvāda · no karma versus material karma · no liberation versus mokṣa and kevala-jñāna.
- △ Shared ground with Jainism: both nāstika, both realist about the perceptible world, both reject a creator God.
- △ Verdict: Cārvāka's ethics is a coherent theory of prudence and an incomplete theory of morality.

MCQ 15

Why, on the Cārvāka's own reasoning, is dharma rejected as a puruṣārtha?

- A. Because pleasure is intrinsically more agreeable than duty, and human beings always pursue the more agreeable.
- B. Because dharma is a scriptural category — "virtue and vice are distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted" — so it falls with śabda, exactly as ākāśa falls with inference.

C. Because dharma was invented by the Jainas and Buddhists, whose authority Cārvāka rejects.

D. Because dharma and mokṣa are identical, and mokṣa is impossible.

✓ Correct answer: B. Chatterjee and Datta give the reason in exactly those words, which shows that Cārvāka ethics is a consequence of the epistemology rather than an independent appetite for pleasure. A reverses the direction of the argument and reduces a normative claim to a psychological one. C is historically false — dharma is a pan-Indian category and pre-eminently a Vedic one. D conflates two distinct puruṣārthas that the sources reject for different reasons.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

MCQ 16

What is the correct scholarly status of the widely quoted line "let a man live happily and feed on ghee even though he runs in debt, for when once the body becomes ashes how can it ever return here"?

A. It is the opening sūtra of the surviving Bṛhaspati-sūtra.

B. It is quoted from Vātsyāyana's Kāma-sūtra, chapter two.

C. It is a verse preserved in the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha — an opponent's fourteenth-century doxographical compendium — and must be presented as a doxographical characterisation of the school's spirit, not as a securely locatable quotation from an extant primary Cārvāka text.

D. It is a canonical Jaina criticism of the Cārvākas, recorded in the Ṣaḍ-darśana-samuccaya.

✓ Correct answer: C. Sharma reproduces the verse within the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha summary of the Cārvāka position, and the authored knowledge file explicitly directs that such lines be presented "as a traditional doxographical verse associated with the Cārvāka image, not as a securely locatable quotation from an extant primary Cārvāka text." A is impossible, since the Bṛhaspati-sūtra is lost. B misattributes it; Vātsyāyana's chapter two is the source of the refined hedonist material, and indeed argues against refusing deferral. D misplaces both the text and the polemical direction.

✓ Subtopic 8 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now present Cārvāka ethics without caricature, handle the source-critical problem of its most famous verse, and run the Jaina comparison on the correct axes. Proceeding to the final synthesis.

Progress: 9 / 9 | Stage: Mastery | Subtopic: Comparative Synthesis and Answer-Writing Architecture

— PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST —

📖 Book context: Carvaka.md §§3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8 (inter-school debates, criticisms and replies, traps, keyword bank, PYQ routing and answer architecture) read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §V ("Conclusion") — including the "touchstone" verdict, the Kant–Hume comparison and the pragmatist / logical-positivist parallel — read directly; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §§I–V read directly for the counterweight verdict; _PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md read in full for the complete routing table and the ownership frequency data.

🔍 CA Search: "Cārvāka / Lokāyata — comparative scholarship, positivism debate, February–August 2026"

📅 CA Found: None in last 6 months. No credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. All four conceptual parallels used across this session — physicalism and emergent consciousness, scientific scepticism, testimonial misinformation, and inference under uncertainty — are explicitly labelled  conceptual links and are not presented as current affairs.



MASTER CONCEPT MAP — the whole syllabus item on one page



1. The master comparison table

Axis	Cārvāka	Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika	Buddhism	Jainism
Pramāṇas	✔ 1 — perception	✔ 4 — perception, inference, comparison, testimony	✔ 2 — perception, inference	✔ Fivefold knowledge; inference admitted
Elements / substances	✔ 4 bhūtas, no ākāśa	✔ 9 dravyas, including ākāśa, ātman, manas	⚠ Dharmas, momentary	✔ 6 dravyas, including ākāśa and kāla
Self	✔ Living body (dehātmavāda)	✔ Eternal substantial ātman	✔ No self; five skandhas, santāna	✔ Infinite jīvas; consciousness their inseparable essence
Consciousness	✔ Emergent by-product of matter	✔ Adventitious quality of ātman	✔ Vijñāna, one conditioned skandha	✔ Essence of the soul, obscured by karma
God	✔ Rejected; svabhāva suffices	✔ Proved by kāryāt, āyojanāt, dhṛtyādeḥ, padāt/śruteḥ	✔ Rejected; conditions suffice	✔ No creator; godhood attained by the siddha
Karma	✔ Rejected as unseen	✔ Accepted; adṛṣṭa, God as dispenser	✔ Accepted; causal-moral continuity	✔ Accepted; karma as subtle matter

Axis	Cārvāka	Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika	Buddhism	Jainism
Rebirth	✓ Rejected	✓ Accepted	✓ Accepted, without a self	✓ Accepted
Liberation	✓ None; maraṇam eva apavargaḥ	✓ Apavarga as cessation of pain	✓ Nirvāṇa	✓ Mokṣa; kevala-jñāna
Vedic authority	✓ Rejected — hence nāstika	✓ Accepted	✓ Rejected	✓ Rejected
Standpoint theory	⚠ None; single standpoint	⚠ None	✓ Saṃvṛti / paramārtha	✓ Anekānta, naya, syādvāda

2. Criticisms and replies — the consolidated grid

#	Criticism	Cārvāka's best reply	Residual assessment
1	✓ Self-refutation: the universal denial of inference is itself inferential; other minds and ideas are never perceived	⚠ Soften the thesis to a denial of apodictic certainty, or restrict it to transcendental inference; or advance no thesis at all (vitaṇḍā)	⚠ Decisive against the strong form; the softened form survives but is a much weaker doctrine
2	✓ Science becomes impossible: without induction, no stable knowledge beyond isolated perceptions	⚠ Practical expectations remain available, tied to future perceptual check	⚠ Saves practice better than theory; narrows Cārvāka into radical empiricist caution
3	✓ Perception itself errs (flat earth, static earth, small sun) — and is corrected by inference	⚠ The corrections are ultimately perceptual and practical; and fallibility about how things appear does not license unperceivable entities	⚠ Adequate for the flat-earth case, weak for heliocentrism; the hierarchy P over I is genuinely threatened
4	✓ Emergence does not explain subjectivity: redness and intoxication are public; consciousness is private, and "neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard"	⚠ Positing an immaterial soul renames the gap rather than closing it	⚠ Both sides face the gap; the Cārvāka at least does not claim to have crossed it
5	✓ Dependence is not production: light is necessary for sight but is not its cause; the two horns of a bull are constantly conjoined but not causally related	⚠ The instrument-hypothesis needs a user, and no user is perceived; materialism is the more economical of two unproven options	⚠ Genuinely undecided; an honest answer says so
6	✓ Crude hedonism: no qualitative distinction among pleasures — "the pleasure of the pig"	⚠ The suśikṣita strand, the sixty-four arts, and Vātsyāyana's prudential regulation of desire	⚠ Supplies prudence and culture, not an independent standard of value
7	? Hostile sources make fair reconstruction impossible	⚠ Convergence across Buddhist, Advaita, Jaina and Vedāntic doxographies fixes a doctrinal core	⚠ Use caution without abandoning content
8	⚠ Same-standpoint inconsistency (Sharma): perception is accepted and inference rejected at the same level, with no vyāvahārika / pāramārthika distinction available	⚠ Adopt the level-distinction as a repair	⚠ Effective, but the repair is the interpreter's, not the school's

3. Five verdicts you may safely defend

⚠ Each of these is defensible, criterion-named and examiner-friendly. Choose according to the question.

1. "Cārvāka's epistemology is more successful as a critique of certainty than as a theory of knowledge."
2. "Cārvāka's ontology is impeccably derived from its epistemology; its vulnerability is therefore located entirely in that epistemology, not in its metaphysics."
3. "Cārvāka wins the argument that finite observation cannot entail an unrestricted universal, and loses the argument that this abolishes inference as a pramāṇa — because Nyāya replaces the demand for omniscient certainty with a demand for disciplined warrant."
4. "Cārvāka denies the transcendence of the self while retaining its substantiality; Buddhism denies its substantiality while retaining its moral continuity. The two denials are not species of one genus."
5. "Cārvāka is a complete theory of prudence and an incomplete theory of morality; its historical value is critical rather than constructive — it was, as Chatterjee and Datta put it, the touchstone on which every other system tested itself."

4. Is Cārvāka positivistic? — the full treatment of the 2024 demand

⚠ The question ("Do you think Cārvāka's philosophy is positivistic in nature? Give reasons and justifications") invites a graded answer. A flat yes or a flat no both lose marks. Structure it as three movements.

⚠ Movement 1 — establish that the label is not imported by the examiner. ✓ Chatterjee and Datta apply it themselves: "The Cārvāka theory on the whole may also be called positivism, because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena." They also compare its view of inference to that of "the pragmatists and logical positivists". This is a decisive evidential point: you are not being asked to invent a comparison, you are being asked to test one already present in the tradition of exposition.

⚠ Movement 2 — the case for the label:

Respect	Cārvāka	Positivism
Criterion of the knowable	✓ Only what is presented in perception	Only what is empirically verifiable
Attitude to metaphysics	✓ Transcendent entities are rejected as unwarranted	Metaphysical statements are rejected as unverifiable
Attitude to theology	✓ God and afterlife have no pramāṇa	Theological statements are cognitively empty
Attitude to authority	✓ Scripture is not an independent source	Revelation is not evidence
Register of dismissal	⚠ Questions about rebirth and heaven become "meaningless" (Chatterjee and Datta's word)	Unverifiable statements are meaningless
Value theory	✓ Naturalistic, this-worldly, consequential	Naturalistic and anti-transcendent

⚠ Movement 3 — the case against, and it is the stronger half:

Respect	Cārvāka	Positivism
Inference	✓ Denied pramāṇa-status — the fatal divergence	Depends utterly on inference; science is systematised inference
Unobservables	✓ Refused	Freely admitted when they earn their explanatory keep
Programme	⚠ Polemical minimalism; no method of confirmation	A constructive programme: unified science, criteria of significance, logical analysis
Tools	⚠ None of formal logic, semantics or probability	Formal logic, verification and confirmation theory, language analysis
Comte's specific content	⚠ Absent	Law of three stages, sociology, a philosophy of history
Fallibilism	⚠ Demands indubitability, then finds nothing meets it	Accepts corrigible, revisable knowledge as the norm

△ The verdict formula. Cārvāka is positivistic in spirit — in its empiricist criterion, its anti-metaphysical temper and its suspicion of unverifiable authority, a resemblance Chatterjee and Datta themselves note. It is not positivistic in method, because positivism is built on the very inference Cārvāka refuses to certify, and possesses a constructive programme that Cārvāka wholly lacks. The safer and more accurate label is radical empiricism or naturalistic materialism; "positivism" is a useful analogy, not a historical identity. △ Add the paradox from Subtopic 5: Cārvāka reaches a materialist conclusion by an anti-inferential route, whereas positivism reaches its conclusions by a thoroughly inferential one.

5. India and the West — convergence and divergence

Western figure or movement	Convergence with Cārvāka △	Divergence △
Epicurus / Lucretius	Materialist atomism; this-worldly ethics; freedom from fear of the gods and of death	Epicurus offers ataraxia and a theory of prudent, qualitatively ordered pleasure; Cārvāka as transmitted offers no such refinement — though the <i>suśikṣita</i> strand approaches it
Hume	Induction cannot be rationally justified; causal relation is not perceived	Hume grounds inference in custom and treats it as psychologically indispensable, retaining it as knowledge; Cārvāka denies it <i>pramāṇa</i> -status outright
Logical positivism (Ayer)	Suspicion of unverifiable metaphysics; the "meaningless" register	Ayer preserves scientific inference and analyses meaning through formal tools absent in India
Comte	Rejection of theological explanation in favour of observable phenomena	Comte's positivism is a philosophy of history and a science of society; Cārvāka has neither
Contemporary physicalism	Consciousness as arising from material organisation	Modern physicalism is inference-driven and posits unobservables freely

△ Chatterjee and Datta's own comparative line, which is safe to quote in substance: the criticism of inference put in the Cārvāka's mouth "reminds us of similar criticism made in modern times against the soundness of deductive logic", and the Cārvāka view "that no inference can yield certain knowledge is the view of many contemporary Western thinkers like the pragmatists and logical positivists." They also compare the school's fate to that of the Epicureans of Greece, who "have been more hated than understood".

6. Answer architecture

△ 10 marks (≈150 words, 7–8 minutes)

1 min : thesis -- perception alone is *pramāṇa*; ontology is its shadow
 4 min : the three doors against *vyāpti* (perception / inference / testimony)
 1 min : ONE sharp addition -- *upādhi*, or the self-refutation charge
 1 min : verdict linking epistemology to the denial in question

△ 15 marks (≈220–260 words, 12–13 minutes)

1 min : frame -- Carvaka as the radical empiricist challenge within Indian philosophy, known through hostile doxography
 4 min : full anti-inference argument: *vyāpti*, class-character reply, *upādhi*, *petitio principii*
 3 min : the rival's positive case (Nyaya's ladder, or Jaina reality, or the objection set on the self)
 3 min : Carvaka's best reply, and its cost
 1 min : graded verdict with a NAMED criterion

△ 20 marks (≈320–360 words, 17–18 minutes)

2 min : classify -- epistemology generating metaphysics; note the source problem
 5 min : theory of knowledge in full, with the three doors and *upādhi*
 4 min : the ontological consequences -- *ākāśa*, *ātman*, *īśvara*, *karma*, *mokṣa*
 4 min : the comparison the question demands, run on NAMED AXES
 2 min : two objections with replies and residual pressure
 1 min : criterion-named graded verdict; avoid caricature

7. PYQ routing — the complete 2018–2025 map

Year	Q	Marks	Demand	Session route
2018	Q8(b)	15	Is Cārvāka's rejection of inference acceptable to the other systems? Are they justified?	Subtopics 3 + 4 (three limbs)
2019	Q5(c)	10	Are the Cārvākas consistent in holding that inference is not a source of knowledge?	Subtopic 3 §7
2019	Q6(c)	15	What is wrong, according to the Cārvākas, with the Socrates syllogism?	Subtopic 3 §6
2020	Q6(b)	15	Rejection of ākāśa; criticism of transmigration	Subtopics 5 §3 + 7 §4
2020	Q7(c)	15	Differences of conception of Reality between Cārvāka and Jainism	Subtopic 8 §6
2021	Q5(e)	10	The bearing of Cārvāka epistemology on the rejection of transcendental entities	Subtopic 7 §7
2024	Q5(a)	10	Is Cārvāka's philosophy positivistic in nature?	Subtopic 9 §4
2024	Q6(a)	20	Cārvāka's refutation of self versus the Buddhist rejection of ātmā	Subtopic 6 §5
2025	Q5(a)	10	The ground on which Cārvāka rejects inference	Subtopic 3 §§1–5
Cross-link	2022 Q7(c)	15	Nyāya's response to Cārvāka's objections against anumāna (owned by Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika)	Subtopic 4

△ Pattern to notice. Five of the nine owned parts concern inference. Two concern the self and transcendent entities. One concerns comparison with Jainism, one the positivism label. The topic's centre of gravity is unambiguously epistemological — so a candidate who has mastered Subtopics 2, 3 and 4 has covered the majority of the historical demand.

8. Original practice — Mains questions for this session

△ Attempt these under time before consulting the workbook, which contains full model solutions.

- (10) Explain why the Cārvāka rejects śabda as an independent pramāṇa, and assess whether the rejection is consistent with his acceptance of perception.
- (10) "Maraṇam eva apavargaḥ." Explain the argument compressed in this Cārvāka sūtra and evaluate it.
- (10) Distinguish svabhāvavāda from yadṛcchāvāda in Cārvāka metaphysics and examine whether they are consistent.
- (15) Examine the Cārvāka doctrine that consciousness is an emergent by-product of the four elements, with the objections it faces.

5. (15) "The Cārvāka's upādhi objection is a stronger argument than his objection from incomplete enumeration." Critically discuss.
6. (15) Assess whether the dhūrta / suśikṣita distinction rescues Cārvāka ethics from the charge of crude hedonism.
7. (15) How far do the surviving sources permit a fair reconstruction of Cārvāka philosophy? Discuss with reference to the Bṛhaspati-sūtra, the doxographies and the Tattvopaplavasīṃha.
8. (20) "Cārvāka's metaphysics is nothing but its epistemology written out as a list of denials." Critically evaluate.
9. (20) Compare the Cārvāka and Nyāya positions on vyāpti, and assess whether Nyāya successfully answers the Cārvāka.
10. (20) Compare the conceptions of reality in Cārvāka and Jainism, and assess which better accounts for change and persistence.

9. Model philosophical conclusion

△ "Cārvāka is the limiting case of Indian philosophy: the position obtained when a single epistemic restriction — that only what is perceived may be admitted — is applied without exception. Everything else follows. Four elements and not five, because ākāśa is inferred; a body-self and not an ātman, because no soul is perceived; nature and not God, because svabhāva discharges the explanatory work; kāma and not dharma, because virtue is a scriptural category. Its failure is that the restriction cannot be stated without being violated: the denial of inference is itself a universal, and the very act of arguing presupposes the other minds that perception never delivers. Its success is that no Indian school could afford to ignore it. Chatterjee and Datta are right that the Cārvāka became the touchstone on which every system tested its theories, and Sharma is right that materialism, born in discontent, soon died in serious thought. Both verdicts hold, because Cārvāka failed as a system precisely to the degree that it succeeded as a challenge."

Final MCQ 17

Which of the following is the most defensible verdict on the question whether Cārvāka's philosophy is positivistic?

- A. It is positivistic in spirit — sharing an empiricist criterion, an anti-metaphysical temper and a suspicion of unverifiable authority, a resemblance the standard textbooks themselves note — but not in method, since positivism is built on the inference Cārvāka refuses to certify and possesses a constructive programme Cārvāka lacks.
- B. It is straightforwardly positivistic, since both hold that only observable phenomena are real.
- C. It is in no sense positivistic, since positivism is a nineteenth-century European movement and no comparison across traditions is legitimate.
- D. It is positivistic because Comte's law of three stages is anticipated in the Bṛhaspati-sūtra.

✓ Correct answer: A. Chatterjee and Datta both apply the label — "may also be called positivism, because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena" — and supply the material that qualifies it, since they also record the Cārvāka's wholesale denial of inference. B ignores the methodological chasm; C refuses a comparison the tradition of exposition has itself already made; D invents a textual claim about a lost text.

You have 1 consecutive correct answer.

Final MCQ 18

An examiner writes in the margin of a Cārvāka answer: "You have described the denials. You have not shown the bearing." What has the candidate failed to do?

- A. Failed to quote the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha.
- B. Failed to derive each ontological denial from the single epistemic premise that perception alone is a pramāṇa, so that ākāśa, ātman, Īśvara, karma, adṛṣṭa, rebirth, svarga and mokṣa all fall by one cut rather than appearing as a list of separate rejections.
- C. Failed to mention the four elements.
- D. Failed to write in Sanskrit.

✓ Correct answer: B. This is the exact demand of 2021 Q5(e), and it is the organising principle of the entire syllabus item: Chatterjee and Datta state that the Cārvāka theory of reality "follows from the epistemological conclusion". A, C and D are matters of ornament or content, not of the logical architecture the examiner is asking for.

✓ Learning session complete: 9/9 subtopics. Final assessment passed with 2 consecutive correct answers.

You now hold the source situation, the sole-pramāṇa thesis, the full anti-inference argument with its replies, the Nyāya counter-case, the materialist metaphysics with both emergence analogies, the self-comparison with Buddhism, the systematic rejection of transcendent entities, the ethics with its refined strand, and the comparative synthesis with complete PYQ routing.

Commands: Revise · PYQ · Notes · Export PDF

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES — Cārvāka / Lokāyata

Placement note: These register notes come after all teaching and practice, and cover every one of the nine subtopics taught in this session. They are the last-mile revision layer, not a substitute for the session above.

Register 1 — Sources, names and historical setting

Item	Register entry
Syllabus wording	✓ "Carvaka : Theory of Knowledge; Rejection of Transcendent Entities" (printed wording retained)
Names	✓ Cārvāka (carv, to chew / cāru-vāk, sweet-worded) · Lokāyata (lokāyata-mata, view of common people) · Bārhaspatya (of Bṛhaspati)
Traditional founder	✓ Bṛhaspati; his Sūtra is lost; about a dozen sūtras survive as quotations
Transmission	✓ Known "chiefly" from works that state the views in order to refute them
Sharma's verdict on sources	✓ "The weak points ... are exaggerated and the strong points are omitted. So we get only a faint caricature and not a true picture"
Key doxographies	✓ Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha (Mādhava) · Ṣaḍ-darśana-samuccaya (Haribhadra) · Prabodhacandrodaya (a play, Kṛṣṇamiśra) · Tattvasaṅgraha (Śāntarākṣita) · Vedāntasāra (Sadānanda)
Only surviving text	✓ Tattvopaplavasīṃha, Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa, c. 8th century CE, published Baroda 1940 — but he attacks perception too and admits not even the elements
Six transmitted sūtras	✓ four elements · bodies-senses-objects from combination · consciousness as intoxicating power · caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ · kāma evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ · maraṇam eva apavargaḥ
Nāstika — exact sense	✓ Rejects the authority of the Veda (primary sense); also denies life after death (secondary sense); nāstika in both
Historical anchors	✓ Ajita Kesakambalī (Majjhima Nikāya; believed only in perception and four elements) · Pūraṇa Kassapa · Makkhali Gosāla · Saṅjaya Belaṭṭhiputta (Sāmaññaphala-sutta)
Causes of its rise (Sharma)	✓ Protest against monism and ritual externals; Upaniṣadic idealism unsuited to commoners; exploitation and social crisis

Item	Register entry
Two standing verdicts	⚠ Chatterjee–Datta: the school was the touchstone of every system · Sharma: "Born in discontent, it soon died in serious thought"
Mnemonic	🔗 ONE, FOUR, TWO, ZERO — one pramāṇa, four elements, two puruṣārthas, zero transcendent entities

Register 2 — Epistemology

- ✓ Thesis: pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda — perception alone is a pramāṇa.
- ✓ "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend logically on their epistemology" (Chatterjee and Datta).
- ✓ The standard demanded: knowledge "about which we can have no doubt" and "which must be true to reality".
- ✓ Both external (bāhya) and internal (mānasa) perception are admitted.
- ✓ Consciousness is established by perception; what is denied is the inference from consciousness to an immaterial bearer.
- ✓ The concession: "in life we very often act unsuspectingly on inference" — but "truth is not an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an accident, and a separable one."
- ⚠ Laukika / vyāvahārika inference (corrigible, perceptually redeemable) versus alaukika / pāramārthika inference (structurally uncheckable). The second is the real target.
- ✓ Śabda in five steps: words are heard, hence perceived → what they mean is unperceived → acceptance runs through "this authority is reliable; all reliable authority should be accepted" → that is inference → hence testimony is "as precarious as inference".
- ✓ The Veda: "the works of some cunning priests who earned their living by duping the ignorant and the credulous".
- ✓ Sharma's reductio: if testimony proved vyāpti, "none would be able to infer anything by himself".
- ⚠ One template kills the rest: upamāna, arthāpatti and anupalabdhi each require an unperceived universal.
- ⚠ Sharma's same-standpoint charge: Śūnyavāda and Advaita reject the ultimate validity of all pramāṇas including perception while retaining empirical validity; the vyāvahārika / pāramārthika distinction is "unknown to the Cārvāka", so accepting perception and rejecting inference at one level is "a thoughtless self-contradiction".
- 🔗 Ledger to reproduce: Cārvāka 1 · Vaiśeṣika and Buddhism 2 · Sāṃkhya-Yoga 3 · Nyāya 4 · Prābhākara 5 · Bhāṭṭa and Advaita 6.

Register 3 — The critique of inference

- ✓ Inference is "a leap in the dark"; some inferences are true only "accidentally".
- ✓ The attack targets the major premise (vyāpti), never syllogistic form.
- ✓ Door 1 — perception: all cases past, present and future can never be surveyed.
- ✓ The class-character (sāmānya) exchange: even dhūmatva cannot be perceptually known, since not all smokes are perceived; and a universal-to-universal relation does not license a particular-to-particular inference. "The difficulty of passing from particulars to the universal ... remains here as before."
- ✓ Door 2 — inference: petitio principii or regress. Sharma: "Induction is uncertain and deduction is argument in a circle. The logicians, therefore, find themselves stuck up in the mud of inference."
- ✓ A causal relation is only a species of invariable relation and inherits the same defect.
- ✓ Door 3 — testimony: its own validity is inferred; and if inference depended on testimony, no one could infer by himself.
- ✓ Upādhi: the wet-fuel condition — one who infers smoke from fire errs, because fire is attended with smoke only where fuel is wet. Unconditionality "cannot be established beyond doubt by perception, as some conditions may always remain hidden".

- ⚠ Upādhi is a problem of the right variable, not of sample size — which is why more observation alone cannot answer it, and why Nyāya must bring in tarka.
- ✓ 2019 Socrates syllogism: the form is granted; "All men are mortal" is the vyāpti; it fails the three doors; the deduction merely re-states an unestablished universal.
- ✓ Self-refutation (Sharma): the denial is itself a universal; thoughts, ideas and other minds are never perceived; "the self-refuted Cārvāka position is called sheer nonsense and no system of philosophy".
- ⚠ Three replies: vitaṇḍā / no-thesis · softened certainty-thesis (strongest) · level-distinction (a repair, not a historical doctrine).
- ⚠ Sharma's tu quoque: flat earth, static earth, small solar disc — perception errs and is corrected by inference; and mere sensation is not knowledge "unless conception or thought has arranged into order ... the loose threads of sense-data" (Tattvasaṅgraha).
- 🔗 Verdict formula: the Cārvāka may be consistent or radical, but not both.

Register 4 — The Nyāya defence

- ✓ The eight-stage ladder: bhūyodarśana → upādhi-elimination → tarka → sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa → vyāptigraha → liṅga-darśana → parāmarśa → anumiti.
- ✓ Anvaya (wherever hetu, there sādhyā) and vyatireka (where no sādhyā, no hetu) — the joint method; systematic search for negative cases, not mere counting.
- ✓ Upādhi is a condition that pervades the sādhyā but not the hetu; a defective universal is restated at the correct level — "fire joined with wet fuel".
- ✓ Tarka is pramāṇa-anugrahaka, not a pramāṇa: it assumes the contradictory and exhibits anīṣṭa-prasaṅga, removing the doubt that blocks vyāptigraha.
- ✓ Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa: the universal is presented through the particular — Nyāya's direct answer to the class-character objection.
- ✓ Parāmarśa: the cognition of the mark as qualified by concomitance is the karaṇa of anumiti — hence, for Nyāya, no "leap" occurs at all.
- ✓ Nirvikalpaka / savikalpaka: determinate perception is already conceptually qualified, so the Cārvāka's "pure given" is either pre-cognitive or not pure.
- ⚠ The decisive move: replace omniscient certainty with disciplined rational warrant. "The Nyāya point is not infallibilism but disciplined justificatory practice."
- ⚠ Honest residue: tarka proves nothing alone; sāmānyalakṣaṇa presupposes realism about universals; only suspected upādhis can be eliminated.
- ✓ Cross-school survey (2018 Q8(b)): Nyāya, Sāṃkhya-Yoga, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism all retain inference; Advaita retains it vyāvahārikaally while denying ultimate validity to all pramāṇas.
- 🔗 Verdict: Cārvāka loses the war and wins a battle — inference survives as warranted, not as indubitable.

Register 5 — Metaphysics and materialism

- ✓ Bridging principle: ontological commitment must not outrun the accepted pramāṇas. Name it as a presupposition.
- ✓ pṛthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni — four bhūtas; tatsamudāye śarīrendriya-viśaya-saṃjñā — bodies, senses and objects from their combination.
- ✓ Living organisms too are elemental combinations, "reduced on death" to the elements.
- ✓ The elements are eternal; only their combinations arise and perish (Sharma). Hence Cārvāka is a realist materialism, not a flux doctrine.
- ✓ Ākāśa rejected "because it is not perceived but inferred" — the Vaiśeṣika inference from sound to an imperceptible substrate is refused.
- ⚠ Cārvāka's most defensible line on sound: naturalise it into the perceptible air, rather than abandon the substance-quality scheme he uses for the four elements.

- ✓ kiṇvāḍibhyo madaśaktivād vijñānam — consciousness arises as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents.
- ✓ Betel (leaf, lime, nut → red): compositional emergence. Fermentation (guḍa → intoxicant): transformational emergence. Two analogies, two distinct objections answered.
- ✓ Consciousness is an "epiphenomenon or by-product of matter"; "matter secretes mind as liver secretes bile".
- ⚠ Explanatory gap: redness and intoxication are public, third-person qualities; consciousness is private and first-personal. Best Cārvāka reply: the soul-hypothesis renames the gap rather than closing it.
- ✓ Pot and potter: clay is the material cause and the potter the efficient cause; the Cārvāka answers with svabhāva — "there is no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design".
- ✓ Three labels from the textbook: naturalism (svabhāvavāda) · mechanism (yadr̥cchāvāda) · positivism ("believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena").
- ⚠ Two uses of svabhāva: deflationary (regularity, with "neither any guarantee that uniformity perceived in the past would continue in future") and substantive (nature in place of God). The "empty label" objection bites only on the second.
- ✓ Sadānanda's Vedāntasāra: four materialist schools identify the self with the gross body, the senses, the vital breaths, or manas. Śāntarākṣita reports Kambalāśvatara holding that consciousness arises from the body associated with vital breaths.
- ⚠ Cārvāka reaches materialism by an anti-inferential route; modern materialism by a thoroughly inferential one.

Register 6 — Self, body and consciousness

- ✓ caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ / caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā — the person is the living body qualified by consciousness. Not the corpse; not "no self at all"; not identity with any single element.
- ✓ Negative argument: "the non-material soul is never perceived".
- ✓ Positive argument: "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind" — if the "I" were different from the body these would be meaningless.
- ✓ Covariation: injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease visibly alter awareness.
- ✓ Consequence: "death of the body means the end of the individual"; questions of previous life, after-life, rebirth, heaven and hell "become meaningless".
- ✓ Sharma's objection battery: self-consciousness versus animal life · swoon, fits, epilepsy and dreamless sleep = body without consciousness · dreams = consciousness "without the living body", and the waking dreamer disowns the dream-body but owns the dream-consciousness · subject cannot be reduced to object · co-existence is not causation (light and sight; the two horns of a bull) · consciousness is "neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard" · consciousness is private · the self-manifestation regress · the non-existence of a surviving soul is equally undemonstrable.
- ⚠ Best evaluative line: the evidence establishes dependence; dependence is compatible with the body being the instrument rather than the cause.
- ✓ Memory: Nyāya/Vedānta invoke ātman · Cārvāka invokes bodily-psychological continuity of one organism · Buddhism invokes santāna, pratisandhāna and (Yogācāra) ālaya-vijñāna carrying bījas.
- ✓ 2024 core contrast: Cārvāka relocates the self into matter; Buddhism dissolves the self into process. Substance retained versus substance abolished.
- ✓ Grounds: Cārvāka's is epistemic (never perceived); Buddhism's is ontological (pratītyasamutpāda, kṣaṇikavāda) and soteriological (self-belief breeds tṛṣṇā).
- ✓ Aftermaths: Cārvāka ends the moral narrative at death; Buddhism preserves karma, rebirth and nirvāṇa without an owner.
- ⚠ The decisive refinement: rūpa is itself one of the five skandhas, so Buddhist anātman rules out the Cārvāka body-self by name.
- ⚠ Foils: Puggalavāda (Vātsīputrīya) inside Buddhism; Sadānanda's four materialisms inside Cārvāka.

Register 7 — Rejection of transcendent entities

- ✓ The template: X is imperceptible → only inference or testimony could reach X → neither is a pramāṇa → X is unwarranted → X is rejected.
- ⚠ Note the gap between withholding assent and denying; the doxographies attribute denial ("the Cārvākas, therefore, prefer atheism"), the argument licenses only the weaker conclusion.
- ✓ God falls twice: epistemically (no pramāṇa) and explanatorily (svabhāva suffices; the world's objects are "fortuitous products of the elements").
- ✓ Adṛṣṭa is named among the casualties — "any unperceived law (like adṛṣṭa)". Its very name means "the unseen", making it the perfect test case.
- ✓ Transmigration requires a separable self, its survival, a carrier of desert, and knowledge of all three. Cārvāka cuts every one.
- ✓ Heaven and hell are "the inventions of the priests"; svarga rests on "the unproved existence of a life after death".
- ✓ The liberation dilemma: freedom of a soul (absurd — there is no soul) · freedom from all pain in this life (impossible — embodiment mixes pleasure and pain) · residue: maraṇam eva apavargaḥ, which "no wise man would willingly work for".
- ⚠ Maraṇam eva apavargaḥ is a reductio of the concept of mokṣa, not a recommendation of death.
- ✓ Three ritual reductions: śrāddha and the traveller's food · food downstairs feeding a person upstairs · jyotiṣṭoma — "why do they not rather sacrifice their own old parents?" The last is an argument from revealed preference.
- ✓ Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha: the Agnihotra, the three Vedas, the three staves and ashes were "made by Nature as the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness"; "the three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons". ? Quote with a source-caution.
- ⚠ Cārvāka's uniqueness: Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism are also non-theistic. Cārvāka alone derives its atheism from its epistemology, and alone discards karma, rebirth and liberation as well.
- ⚠ Internal tension worth flagging: svabhāvavāda grounds regularity in fixed natures; yadṛcchāvāda calls the world "fortuitous".

Register 8 — Ethics and social meaning

- ✓ kāma evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ — enjoyment is the only end; artha is its means; dharma and mokṣa are rejected.
- ✓ Dharma falls on epistemic grounds: "virtue and vice are distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted".
- ✓ Criterion: a good action yields a balance of pleasure; a bad one brings more pain than pleasure. Hence hedonism.
- ✓ Dhūrta (cunning / crude) versus suśikṣita (cultured / refined) Cārvākas — "the Cārvākas were not all of the same gross, uncultured type".
- ✓ Evidence for refinement: sixty-four fine arts (catuḥ-ṣaṣṭi-kalāḥ) · daṇḍanīti and vārttā incorporated into Lokāyata · some Cārvākas "regard the king as God", implying faith in society and its head.
- ✓ Vātsyāyana is "the best positive evidence of refined hedonism", but he "believes in God and in life after death" and is a materialist only "according to a wider sense of the term" — one who explains higher phenomena by lower.
- ✓ Vātsyāyana's regulation: brahmacarya, urbanity (nāgarika-vṛtti), education of the senses through the arts; and the prudential argument that refusing to defer "would prevent a man even from the toil of cultivation and sowing seeds".
- ✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is not compatible with social discipline."
- ⚠ Sharma's counterweight: "crude individual hedonism"; the school's downfall lay in "the denial of all human values"; "the pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher."
- ? The "debt and ghee" verse — "let him feed on ghee even though he runs in debt" — is preserved in the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha, an opponent's compendium. Use with an explicit source-caution; its buried argument concerns the rationality of deferral under a finite horizon, and Vātsyāyana himself answers it.
- ⚠ Verdict: Cārvāka's ethics is a coherent theory of prudence and an incomplete theory of morality — it supplies no qualitative ordering of pleasures and no independent account of other-regarding obligation.

Register 9 — Comparative synthesis and answer craft

Item	Register entry
2020 Jainism axes	✓ 1 pramāṇa vs fivefold knowledge · 4 bhūtas vs 6 dravyas · ākāśa rejected vs accepted · no soul vs infinite jīvas with consciousness as inseparable essence · no guṇa-paryāya vs utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya · single standpoint vs anekānta, naya, syādvāda · no karma vs material karma (bhāvabandha, dravyabandha) · no liberation vs mokṣa and kevala-jñāna
Shared ground with Jainism	✓ Both nāstika; both realists about the perceptible world; both reject a creator God
2024 positivism verdict	⚠ Positivistic in spirit (empiricist criterion, anti-metaphysics, "meaningless" register — and the textbook itself applies the word), not in method (positivism runs on inference and has a constructive programme). Safer labels: radical empiricism, naturalistic materialism
The paradox to quote	⚠ Cārvāka reaches materialism by an anti-inferential route; modern materialism by an inferential one
Western convergences	⚠ Epicurus and Lucretius (materialism, this-worldliness) · Hume (induction unjustifiable) · Ayer (unverifiable metaphysics) · Comte (observable phenomena). Chatterjee and Datta themselves compare the Cārvāka view of inference to "the pragmatists and logical positivists" and the school's reputation to that of "the Epicureans of Greece"
10-mark spine	Thesis → three doors → one sharp addition (upādhi or self-refutation) → verdict linking epistemology to the denial asked about
15-mark spine	Frame with the source caution → full anti-inference argument → the rival's positive case → Cārvāka's best reply and its cost → graded verdict with a named criterion
20-mark spine	Classify (epistemology generating metaphysics) → theory of knowledge in full → ontological consequences → the demanded comparison on named axes → two objections with replies and residual pressure → criterion-named verdict
PYQ centre of gravity	✓ 5 of 9 owned parts concern inference; 2 the self and transcendent entities; 1 the Jaina comparison; 1 the positivism label
Criteria to name in verdicts	⚠ Evidential economy · explanatory adequacy · internal consistency · perceptual redeemability · moral sufficiency · historiographical reliability
The five safe verdicts	⚠ Critique of certainty, not a theory of knowledge · ontology impeccably derived, so vulnerability lies in the epistemology · wins on entailment, loses on pramāṇa-status · relocation versus dissolution of the self · complete prudence, incomplete morality
Final memory spine	🌀 ONE, FOUR, TWO, ZERO · three doors · wet fuel · betel and fermentation · "I am fat, I am lame, I am blind" · maraṇam eva apavargaḥ · dhūrta and suśikṣita · touchstone

End of the complete learning session.